empty-handed, facing death

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34683403.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Canon Compliant, YES this is possible please trust me, Time Loop, Time Travel, Temporary Character Death, Episode: s05e05 Save The Cat, Slightly more than canon-typical violence, Angst, Extreme angst, Angst with an (eventual) happy ending, Mind Control, Implied/Referenced Torture, Chipped Catra, I am so sorry

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by Cheesybiscuit

Summary

Adora is going to save Catra. Or at least, that's what she thought before it all fell apart. One huge mistake leaves Adora broken and Horde Prime victorious… until She-Ra's magic changes everything. With one last desperate chance, Adora attempts to rescue Catra again. And again. And again.

or:

Save the Cat, on a time loop.

Notes

This is a reminder to read the tags, and trust me no matter how bad it gets.

Enjoy.

have to try

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora sits stiffly in the captain's seat, sharp eyes taking in the pinpricks of light winking against a dark expanse. She is in space, but she is not looking at stars.

Instead, her field of view is dominated by a massive dagger of a ship; dots of faint green illumination bleed through an ashen exterior, proving a sterile facsimile of the deep, rich purple that forms the wider universe around it.

With every passing second, Adora draws nearer and nearer to Horde Prime's ship, and her heart is racing. With a sound like a Horde tank crumpling to a metal pulp, Darla shudders. Immediately, the ship's sensors go off, and a warning from the display bathes the cabin in crimson.

"Alert. We are being pulled in by an outside force."

Adora's rigid body goes even tenser when she hears Darla's stilted modulation. She furrows her brow in response, but says nothing. This is all part of the plan, no matter how reckless it might be.

With an eerie tranquility, Darla glides toward an opening in the spire, the imposing maw of a hangar. The ship alights with a shift of its wings, and a momentary silence settles over everything.

Adora rises from her seat and swiftly makes her way to the boarding ramp. In the darkness, she takes her position. Nervous fingers find the cool metal of her compacted staff. Her jaw clenches.

The doors slide open to reveal the stark white interior of Prime's flagship. Darla's ramp extends, and a quintuplet of clones make

themselves known, waiting for the ship's passengers with uniform stances and intimidating height.

Adora lets out a low growl at the sight of her enemy. Rage overtakes her, and without waiting for a signal she rushes forward, extending her staff as she does.

A determined yell escapes her throat as she throws herself at the clones, swinging and bashing. The first clone falls, but the second grunts as he stops Adora's staff with a powerful hand. He bares his teeth, and Adora instinctively kicks, planting a foot squarely into his chest and knocking him backward. Her weapon is freed, and the three remaining clones round on her.

"Now!"

Adora's desperate cry rings through the spacious hangar, and she is reinforced by her friends, attacking from above.

Glimmer leaps wildly down onto the back of a clone, while one to her left is struck by an arrow that leaves him a tangled mess of rope. Adora grins as she takes on the third, and Entrapta uses her hair to come down from the ship with a triumphant cackle.

Another swing, and Adora's clone is down. Glimmer has put her hands together and targeted her clone's neck port, effectively knocking him out. She jumps up with a glint in her eye, and pumps a fist in the air.

"Yes! We did it!" she exclaims.

Bow drops to the hangar floor and joins them, removing his helmet and folding his bow.

"Alright, where do we go from here?"

His question is answered by a beaming Entrapta, who has popped off her own helmet and is closely examining a data pad.

“There must be a server room somewhere on board. After we reach Catra, we should be able to gather data on how Prime operates! Ooh, I hope there’s more clones!”

Bow raises an eyebrow, but Adora steps forward and says, “We’d better hope there’s not too many. Glimmer, lead the way.”

The group sets out from the hangar and approaches the hallway. Glimmer carefully peeks around the corner, but there is nothing to find. Three identically vacant corridors stretch out before them, devoid of life or any acknowledgement of the danger the friends have just braved. Adora’s eyes narrow.

“I don’t like this,” she mutters to nobody in particular. “How do we even know where to go? Have you seen this part of the ship, Glimmer?”

Glimmer shakes her head.

“No. At least, I don’t think so.... Maybe? This is just how it is here! This is basically what it looked like outside my cell.”

Adora properly frowns.

“The whole ship looks the same?”

“Pretty much. The only way to know if it’s a new hallway is the rooms, they have these green shields over them. Kind of like something from the Fright Zone, but weirder and... worse. We’ll just have to wander until we find her.”

Three sets of eyes look to Adora in unison, all asking the same question; she responds without hesitation.

“Then let’s start wandering. We’re finding her, no matter what.”

Adora’s projected confidence, as always, belies her true feelings: she is adrift in a sea of unfamiliarity, and she’s gasping for air.

With the Sword of Protection in pieces and the unpredictable arrival of Adora's brand-new (and so far unreplicated) access to some sort of magic, She-Ra's status is… in flux. Traversing through space adds a layer of risk she never could have anticipated, and the very existence of Horde Prime is still something she struggles to wrap her mind around. Glimmer is back with her friends and she's safe, but it's evident that some wounds need time to heal. What troubles Adora most, though, is Catra.

The sole reason they're aboard this vessel is to rescue Catra, though her whereabouts, or even her condition, remain a mystery. Adora recalls the transmission, and Catra's words echo in her skull.

"Don't come here. No matter what. Horde Prime is ready for you!"

And yet, here they are. Adora's long past worrying about threats from tyrants, and with Catra in danger...

"I'm sorry! For everything!"

After all this time, after all these *years,* she chooses now to apologize. Instinct tells Adora that she should be angry, but she instead finds her eyes damp with tears.

The sole reason they're *really* aboard this vessel is because Catra sacrificed herself to save Glimmer. Adora is still in shock, and the moment plays on a loop in her head. She hears the desperation and fear in Catra's voice. She contemplates the meaning, turning it all over in her mind and worrying it like one might a hangnail. Ever since the portal, Adora's told herself not to dream, to wish. But this…

This is impossible to ignore.

And now, every once-suppressed hope bubbles up inside her, a powerful and heady cocktail of that unnamed emotion, that unspoken connection. Adora doesn't even know if Catra is alive, but she has to try.

She's bringing Catra *home.*

Adora is brought back to the present when she nearly collides with Glimmer. The Queen has stopped in place and is silently holding up a fist. A beat passes, and a pair of clones stride through the intersection, headed away from them. After what feels like a lifetime, their footsteps fade and leave the group in isolation.

Entrapta takes the opportunity to glance at her tracker pad and whisper excitedly, "I'm getting a *biiiiig* energy reading. There's something powerful on board, and we might be headed right for it!"

Adora quirks an eyebrow, wondering what that could possibly be.

Before she's able to voice her question, Glimmer says softly, "That's got to be the server room. I don't think that's too far from the cell, c'mon."

The corridors of Prime's ship remain largely deserted, and after they pass by their third intersection, Entrapta remarks, "This place is so big, and empty! Where are the vents? How does anyone get around in this place?"

Bow chuckles, and says, "I don't think this ship was designed for people who aren't… you know." He draws himself up to his full height and imitates the scowl of a clone, and Adora can't help but smile.

Glimmer, meanwhile, has been staring intently at the hallway opposite them. Adora takes notice, and places a hand on her friend's shoulder.

"What's going on?"

Glimmer gives a start at the contact, but relaxes when she turns back to see Adora. She lets out a sigh, and slumps back against the wall, staring intently at the floor.

"Sorry, this is just… it's a lot, being back here. I keep worrying that he's gonna come around every corner, and that we won't be able to get away."

Adora nods in understanding, and attempts to comfort Glimmer.

"I don't know everything you went through while you were here, but I'm going to make sure it can never happen again. It's brave of you to come back, especially for… well, for Catra."

Glimmer looks up, and there's worry in her eyes.

"I made it out, and that's what matters. I just hope we can say the same for her."

A chill goes down Adora's spine, and she has to force herself to speak again.

"T-then let's get going."

After checking for clones, the group sets out once more. They don't have far to go; just three corridors later, a faint glow from ahead makes Glimmer gasp softly.

She whispers, "Up there, that's it. That's the cell."

Adora's breath catches.

Catra's in that cell. She's in there and I need to—

Before she knows what she's doing, before she can steel herself and process the fact that Catra may be mere feet away, her body is carrying her forward.

She sprints toward the cell, no longer worried about keeping quiet, and suddenly the world is just her and the light up ahead. The glow becomes brighter and a frantic moment later, the entire wall is dominated by a translucent green energy field. It's reminiscent of a Horde cell, but larger, more refined. Adora skids to a halt right in front of it, and looks inside to discover…

Nothing.

The cell is empty, and there is no sign of Catra.

No...

Adora's friends are just paces behind her, and they gather quietly at her side. She continues to stare at the wall, and her mind is becoming a swirl of dread and doubt.

Where is she? Is she still alive? Where could she have been taken? Was this all a trap? Is she—

Bow interrupts her spiraling thoughts by wrapping an arm around her in a loose hug. Adora reluctantly turns from the vacant cell and hugs back, trying her hardest not to cry.

"It'll be okay, Adora. We'll find her."

Bow's deep voice rumbles against her frame, and he says his words with such conviction that they ground her a little, despite the fear. Where would she be without her friends?

Adora bites back her tears, and sucks down a deep breath through clenched teeth.

"Yeah, we will. Thanks, Bow."

Her burgeoning panic begins to give way to singular focus. It's another beat before she can think clearly again, and when she does, she finds herself right back to asking questions, though these seem more productive.

Catra must be in another part of the ship. Maybe with Prime? There has to be somewhere else...

Adora vocalizes her thoughts, and asks, “Glimmer, is there anywhere else she might be? Anywhere at all that you know of?”

Glimmer frowns, and says, “Maybe. Let me think.”

Behind her, Entrapta lets out a small, “Oooh.” Her prehensile hair is extended toward the force field of the cell, while her hands are busy tapping away at her data pad. If Adora were focused on anything besides Catra’s safety, she might wonder what’s so interesting about the green sheet of energy.

“Prime has a sort of throne room,” Glimmer says. “That’s where we came in, when we got… teleported. I was only there for a few minutes, but I think I remember the way from here.”

Adora’s mind lights up with images of Hordak’s Sanctum, and a hard, angular throne that he never seemed to get up from.

“Will Prime be there?” she asks, not yet sure of what she intends to do.

Glimmer nods. “Probably.”

Adora says nothing in response, simply deploying her staff and fixing Glimmer with a look that she can only hope will communicate her plan. Glimmer seems to understand, and gives a small nod.

She mutters “Let’s go,” and moves swiftly into the darkened corridor stretching out before them. Adora eagerly follows suit, glancing behind her just long enough to confirm that Entrapta has gotten the message; an enthusiastic purple-haired thumbs-up is all she needs, and the group is on their way.

Their pace has quickened significantly, and Adora can sense that something around them has changed. She isn’t able to place it, but her eyes dart back and forth all the same. A crawling sensation on her skin tells her they’re being observed.

They take alternating turns at three intersections, before once again emerging into a well-lit hallway. This one's different though: higher-than-normal ceilings accommodate an enormous diamond-shaped force field at the end, and a lace pattern of struts around the edges indicate its importance. Two clones flank the massive door, and reinforce what the design already loudly broadcasts. Adora's pulse picks up.

This is it.

Their arrival does not go unnoticed, and the clones immediately glower, moving in their direction.

Adora lets out a yell and charges forward, trusting that behind her, Bow has unshouldered his weapon and already taken aim. Sure enough, the clone to the left is struck with an exploding arrow that leaves him staggering.

Adora meets her opponent in the middle of the hall, and sweeps his legs with her staff's longer reach. He tumbles to the floor, where Adora jabs her weapon into his neck port. He grunts once and then falls silent.

Glimmer rushes forward with nothing but her fists, and she lands a powerful punch on the first disoriented clone. He hits the ground with a dull *thud,* and then the corridor is silent.

"The clones seem to have a weakness at the base of their neck! Fascinating…"

Entrapta's observation breaks through the post-brawl tension, and she strides past the carnage toward the imposing force field.

"It's so tall! How does it function?"

Glimmer grabs for the arm of a clone, and with Bow's help, drags it nearer to the door.

"They work when the clones touch them, but I don't know why," she replies. And then, looking at Adora, she asks, "Are you

ready?”

It’s a simple enough question, yet Adora struggles to procure an answer. She is swamped by emotions, feeling a veritable symphony: anger, fear, guilt, uncertainty—but she finds it all means so little in the face of the one constant in her life, the one unwavering truth.

Catra.

It doesn’t matter what she’s done, it doesn’t even matter that the chances of survival are slim. What matters is that Catra is behind this door. And nobody, not even Horde Prime, will stand in Adora’s way.

She takes a deep breath, and sets her jaw.

“I’m ready. Open it.”

* * *

The sheet of viridescent energy dissipates and reveals a void, impossibly large and as dark as space. Whatever Adora was expecting, it wasn’t this.

A walkway stretches out from the doorway into the nothing, on and on and on until it connects to a platform in the center of the chasm. Adora takes a step that’s far more confident than she feels, and begins the trek to her fate.

Her friends are right behind her, moving swiftly and carefully. Adora expects their steps to echo, but the vast chamber simply absorbs the sound. She shudders.

What Adora *can* hear is the soft chirps of Entrapta’s awestruck curiosity, the rhythmic huff of Glimmer’s anxious breaths, and her

own pulse pounding in her ears.

Up ahead, a beam of light from the unseen ceiling illuminates the central platform, where a pair of clones stand at attention. Between them is a throne, and on that throne is…

Prime. That has to be him.

As the group draws nearer, Adora's heart beats louder. Her grip on her staff tightens. They're close enough now that she can finally take in the details, and what she sees horrifies her.

Horde Prime is alien yet familiar, imposing yet sophisticated. Glimmer had talked of him briefly, but no amount of description could prepare Adora for his presence, so immediate and terrifyingly *real.*

Unlike the eyes of the clones, Prime's shine icily with life, shrewd and all-knowing. They look right through her, seeming to bore into her very soul, attacking her with intensity, and yet… nothing has happened. No fight has broken out. Prime simply lounges on his throne, watching them with those four eyes and wearing a bored expression while his clones stand by.

Adora furrows her brow, and resolves to act before Prime has a chance to.

"Where is she?"

Prime's mouth slowly curls into a smile, though it could not be mistaken for one of mirth. He says nothing. Adora, frustrated at the lack of response, calls out again.

"Where is Catra? Tell me."

Prime begins to laugh, and it's an uncanny sound. It is recognizably Hordak, and yet it is not Hordak at all. Hordak never laughed, but if he did, Adora thinks this is what it must sound like: cruel, cold, calculated. When Prime speaks, it's somehow even worse.

“Catra is safe, do not worry Adora. She has been put at peace, made better.”

Adora almost recoils at the sound of her name, but instead chooses to bare her teeth and take a pointed step forward. It’s a mistake; the moment she does, Prime snaps his fingers.

The clones at his side rush forward to restrain Adora, and her staff clatters to the floor as her arms are pinned behind her back.

“Adora!” Bow cries, but before he can react, more clones swarm from behind and similarly incapacitate him, Glimmer, and Entrapta. The entire struggle is over in less than five seconds.

“No!” Adora yells, thrashing against her captors. “Let us go!”

Prime unhurriedly rises from his throne, surveying the group. He paces closer, coming to a stop in front of Entrapta.

“Another Princess from Etheria, it would appear. To what do I owe this great pleasure?”

Entrapta frowns and refuses to meet Prime’s eyeline, a soft whimper her only response. He ignores his unanswered question, instead saying, “I see you’ve brought a friend!”

His gaze falls on Bow, who shudders under the scrutiny. Prime strides down the line, this time towering over Glimmer.

“And Queen Glimmer, how bold of you to return to me. I suspect you shall meet the same fate as the foolish creature who attempted to rescue you.”

Glimmer gasps, and Adora’s blood runs cold.

“What did you do to her?” Adora asks in a wavering voice. She’s beginning to panic at her lack of control, and the possibility that Catra has been hurt is nearly too much to bear.

Horde Prime turns to her and says in a cloying tone, “Ah, and Adora. Of course.”

As he speaks, he reaches out a clawed hand and touches Adora’s face in a knowing, possessive gesture. It’s Shadow Weaver all over again, and Adora jerks back in disgust.

“I said, what did you do to her?!”

Prime just smirks, a terrible sight.

“See for yourself.”

Adora is suddenly beset by the horrible sensation of being watched, and she knows somewhere deep in her gut that Catra is behind her.

She immediately strains against the clones, grunting and fighting for a glimpse over her shoulder, anything to see Catra, and then...

A flash of white, a small figure.

Catra strides past Adora, flanked by yet more clones.

She stands stiffly at Horde Prime’s side, and it’s Catra, yes, but she’s wearing a hood, a brand new outfit. Her eyes glow unnaturally, everything is sterile, and Adora is frozen in shock.

“Hello, Adora.”

The words hang awkwardly in the space between them while the hood is lowered, revealing shorn and slicked-back hair, a blank expression, and Catra’s not right, this isn’t *right*—

“No no no no, what did—what have you *done* to her?!”

“I have brought her into the light,” Prime gloats. “She was in such pain, you know, and all because you left her. I’ve merely granted her peace.”

It’s Glimmer who speaks up, growling, “Catra never would have wanted this! You’re a monster.”

Adora is momentarily stunned by Glimmer’s defense, but recovers quickly and shouts at Prime, “She’s right! This is some sort of trick, it has to be. Y-you don’t know anything about me, or Catra.”

Prime chuckles darkly, dangerously.

“Oh, Adora… I have heard her thoughts, felt her pain. It would seem I know her better than you ever did.”

His words needle and sting, and Adora shakes with rage, yelling, “Enough! This ends now! Let Catra go.”

Horde Prime replies coolly, “You’re wrong, I’m afraid. This ends only once you’ve given me what I want: She-Ra.”

Glimmer says, “No…” and Adora’s eyes widen with realization, her pulse racing.

He still wants She-Ra? Doesn’t he know she’s gone?

Prime just smiles again, and says, “Oh yes, I know about your planet’s weapon, *and* the power you possess, all courtesy of our little sister.”

As he speaks, Prime rests a clawed hand on Catra’s shoulder. Adora notices that despite the trance-like state Catra is in, she flinches at the touch; Adora sees red.

Voice low, she says, “If you touch her again, I’ll kill you.”

Horde Prime narrows his eyes.

“A futile endeavor. Her place”—Prime’s grip on Catra tightens dangerously—”is by my side.”

A grimace flashes over Catra's face, and something inside of Adora snaps.

There's a pounding in her skull and a rush of adrenaline so potent that she nearly mistakes it for magic. Before she knows what's happening, she's knocking aside her captors with bashing elbows, closed fists, and a frenzied cry ripping from her throat.

The clones hit the floor, Adora scrabbles for her staff.

Her hands close around the solid metal, she rushes toward Prime.

She explodes with a powerful swing aimed right at his taunting face, those cruel eyes, and—

The staff stops in midair, caught by Catra's inflexible and unswaying grasp.

For a quiet moment, she is as still as a statue, a look of manufactured serenity upon her angular face. And then the staff is ripped from Adora's hands and flung, over the edge of the platform and down, down into the endless chasm. Adora hardly registers what's happened, and is instead staring at Catra in horror.

The moment is shattered when Adora is suddenly dragged backward by a fresh pair of clones, who roughly pin her arms to her side and dig their claws into her skin. Pain shoots through her body, but all Adora can do is keep gaping at Catra, feeling more helpless than ever.

"You would dare attack me?"

Horde Prime's voice cuts through the vast chamber with deadly intent. Adora's heart stops.

Prime continues slowly, saying, "I desire only peace and order, which I have provided to this troubled soul. And yet here you are, to take that away. Even as you seek to rescue her, you continue to be at odds with Catra… how disappointing."

Any sliver of control Adora thought she had is now slipping through her hands.

"I'm not—this isn't Catra! I'm trying to—"

Trying to what? That wasn't magic, I'm not She-Ra anymore. I can't fight Prime—

Adora is flooded with doubt and panic, and she begins to hyperventilate. The only thing that keeps her focused is some deep-rooted and stubborn instinct to prove Horde Prime wrong, to prove her dedication to her best friend.

"C-Catra?" she calls, desperately trying to even out her breathing. "Catra, are you in there? This isn't you, it's some sort of trick that Prime—"

"There is no trick, Adora," Catra interrupts, voice as blank as her eyes. "I am in Prime's light now. Everything is as it should be."

Tears stream down Adora's face. She is at a loss, on the edge.

She cries wildly, "What did you do?!"

Prime returns his grip to Catra's shoulder, and Adora is keenly aware that his claws are nearly at Catra's throat; this is a warning.

"I took this *pathetic* life and remade her in my image. The same will be done to your friends… unless, of course, you give me what I want. I will not ask again: give me She-Ra. Only then will your friends walk free."

Adora's heart pounds in her throat, and her entire frame is wracked by sobs. Prime's ultimatum is impossible to reckon with. How could this have gone so wrong so quickly?

She knows this is all her fault. She knows with sickening certainty that this is because she was reckless enough to come here without a plan, to come here without She-Ra…

And if Prime were to somehow get his hands on her magic—but she *isn't* magic, at least that's what her doubt is telling her, and now it's all falling apart, her friends are going to die because of *her*—

"Don't do it, Adora!"

Bow's words ring through her head and provide the barest hint of clarity; they're soon joined by the panicked shouts of Glimmer and Entrapta.

"He can't use the Heart, Adora! We'll be okay, just don't give him what he wants!"

"She's correct, giving Prime access to She-Ra would have devastating consequences!"

Adora is torn by their words; she knows she can't possibly risk the universe for this, but she also knows better than to trust anything Prime says. She wonders what Catra would think, but Catra *can't* think, and she's trapped in the clutches of this tyrant...

It hardly matters now, and Prime looks on impatiently. All she can focus on is Catra's face, screwed up in pain once more, and Adora knows she has only seconds to answer, to think of something, anything—

"I ca—you're a liar!" she shouts at Prime. "I will *never* give you She-Ra. And if you touch her one more time—"

"Silence!" Horde Prime roars. "You thought yourself worthy to challenge *me,* but your kind are nothing. You are a stain to be

wiped clean."

The chamber becomes smaller, and Adora's throat is closing up. She can't blink, she knows somewhere deep down that there's no going back—

"How quickly you have proven to me that none among you are deserving of my good graces. Not even this one"—Catra cries out in pain—"will truly be pure! Twice you have refused me, so now I will take She-Ra from you by *force.* Your friends, your Catra… they have been led to their destruction. You have not obeyed me, and they are nothing but a *waste* to me now."

Panic like she's never felt takes Adora by storm. Catra's face contorts in agony.

"No, please!! Let her go!"

Horde Prime bores into her with those terrible eyes, and says with finality, "You will suffer as she did. And she will suffer no more."

Prime tightens his grip.

He lifts Catra by the throat, and crushes her neck beneath a clawed hand.

Her broken form drops with the weight of lifelessness.

Adora screams.

It is a haunting sound. It mingles with the cries of her friends and the thunderous pounding in her head.

She drops to her knees, throat stripped raw.

The clones no longer restrain her, and Adora stumbles her way to Catra's side, kneeling over her body.

Catra, who for so long has been an impossibly vibrant presence in her life. Even on the battlefield or during their worst moments,

Catra was a flame.

Now, she is a hollow husk, so tiny and shattered...

Adora reaches out with trembling hands and gently cradles Catra. She supports her head, strokes her hair.

When Adora brushes her cheek, she knows for certain that Catra is gone.

At the realization, something inside of her breaks. The information is too much to process. Everything but Catra fades into nothing.

Catra can't be dead, this is a bad dream. It's… it's not real…

Adora numbly repeats the words to herself, until suddenly she feels another surge of adrenaline. It's powerful and urgent, strikingly similar to what she felt back in that cave, when she had dared to hope that She-Ra had returned.

Only now, instead of strength and determination, it is warped.

It feels *wrong.*

Her numbness falls away, and Adora is once again aware of the outside world. Her pulse races dangerously.

There's something building inside of her, and it's dread, it's fear, it's rejection of the truth. It's involuntary, magic that Adora can't command…

Her breath catches in her lungs and there's something in her gut, a physical tugging that feels like falling.

Adora looks around in panic and horror, and through her tears she can see a blue glow beginning to form.

She-Ra…?

The glow is sickly and pale, almost an imitation of her previous magic, and her skin shines with sweat. Adora fruitlessly clings

tighter to Catra, sobbing once more, helpless in the face of this terrible power…

The tugging in her gut becomes a sharp pain, and there's a feeling of siphoning, like the healing magic she's so used to. The pain escalates into a searing heat and Adora lets out a gasp. The glow gets brighter, her vision blurs, and this is so like She-Ra but so *unlike* She-Ra and it's all wrong and—

The grounding sensation of Catra in her arms begins to fade.

"No!! No no—"

She sees white, and her entire body becomes fire.

* * *

"—no no!"

Adora snaps into herself, words already on her lips, but Catra is gone. She is left holding nothing, nobody.

The sudden lack of pain shocks her into alertness, and she's instantly aware that things are different.

Her pulse is still out of control, but…

She-Ra's magic, whatever it was, has disappeared.

Adora is sitting down.

Adora is in a plain room, one that's familiar and old.

Adora sees lights, far away in an expanse of black.

She is in space, but she is not looking at stars.

She is aboard Darla, staring at Horde Prime's ship… and her friends are nowhere to be found. They must still be on board, and she's been transported here, so far away from them, from Catra and Prime and unable to save anyone—

Adora rushes out of the captain's seat and takes in the empty deck, tears flowing freely.

"No…"

She runs to the console, pointlessly reading data she can't understand. She slams a fist down on the smooth metal, crying out, "Catra!! Glimmer!"

"Adora?"

Glimmer's voice comes from nowhere, and Adora looks around frantically.

"Glimmer?! Where are you? Are you okay??"

Glimmer scoffs.

"Yeah, I'm fine. Are *you* okay? What's going on?"

"But Prime—Catra is—where… how are you—"

"Adora, chill out! We're stuck on the outside of Darla, just like you said. We're still gonna rescue Catra, right? Kick Horde Prime's ass?"

Adora is bewildered.

"I don't… you're safe?"

Entrapta chimes in, excitedly saying, "Yes! All spacesuits are standing up to the ship's velocity, with zero loss of life!"

"Wait, what? That was a possibility?"

They're fine? But Catra is…

Turbulence rocks the ship, and a warning appears on the console, splashing red light around the cabin.

Adora furrows her brow, and she can't shake a feeling of familiarity.

"Alert. We are being pulled in by an outside force."

She flashes back an hour, when she'd lived through this exact situation. But that was before Prime, before Catra was crushed and—

It's like she hits a mental block, something in the back of her mind that tells her *no, don't think about it. Maybe it was a trick. Maybe Catra's still alive.*

Unaffected by Adora's crisis, Darla is pulled forward into the hangar of Prime's flagship. On instinct, Adora's fingers find her compacted staff on her belt. But no, her staff was thrown into the abyss. This isn't right...

Darla lands, and Adora rushes to the doors. She *has* to figure this out.

There's a pounding in her head again, fresh and unrelenting. A million questions crowd her mind but the only thing she thinks of is Catra, her limp body, the tricks that Horde Prime plays...

I need to get to Catra, no matter what...

The ramp extends down into the stark white hangar, and Adora follows it, retracing her steps from just an hour before.

A group of clones gathers at the foot of the ramp, and Adora wipes away her tears. She's breathing fast, trying so hard to put the doubt out of her mind.

If there's even the slightest possibility that Catra's still on this ship, she's going to find her and bring her home. Properly this time.

She clenches her jaw, heart racing.

Adora tightly grips the staff that shouldn't be, and rushes toward the clones with a desperate, heart-broken cry.

Chapter End Notes

> If you've made it this far, thank you! This is my most ambitious project yet, and despite the pain, I am very excited and motivated.
>
> I'm aiming for chapter 2 to be out in four weeks, on **Saturday, November 20th.**
>
> Title from Hurt Me by Charly Bliss.
>
> As always, comments and feedback mean the absolute world. I'll see you all in a few weeks!

trial and recursive error

Chapter Summary

"Failure is a vital part of all scientific endeavor."

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The journey to the throne room is a blur in Adora’s mind.

Her friends have emerged from their hiding place.

There are clones sprawled out on the floor.

Catra is so clearly *not* in that cell.

Adora’s heart beats with urgency and horror, but her companions fail to take notice.

She frantically rushes through identical corridors, recalling the path with preternatural understanding, all the while ignoring her friends’ concerned queries. In her dash, she outpaces them, sprinting forward and forward and forward until she bursts into the void once more and crosses the walkway yet again.

She’s greeted by Prime, lounging in his seat like a bored snake.

There’s a beat of dry silence, and Adora shreds it with a frustrated yell.

“What did you do to her?!”

Prime’s eyes flash with a familiar look of skepticism, before he speaks in his hollowly polite timbre.

“Adora! It’s good to finally meet you. I’ve heard so much about you from your… friends.”

The pounding in Adora’s head only grows, but before she can cut through this charade, her friends catch up to her.

Glimmer pants, “Adora, what the he—” but cuts herself off when she sees Horde Prime.

Entrapta lets out a nervous whimper, and Prime rises from his throne.

“More of you? What an honor to host acquaintances of the great *She-Ra.”*

Adora quickly spins around toward her friends, her ponytail whipping behind her. She turns back to Prime, her grasp on this already absurd situation slipping by the second.

“I do—what have you done?! Where is she? What happened to me?”

“Ah, of course... you must be wondering where your Catra is. Rest assured, she is safe.”

Adora’s face contorts in pain and grief.

“Safe?! You killed her! I watched you kill her, you’re a monster!!”

Prime spreads his arms wide in a gracious gesture, and smiles without warmth.

“You are mistaken. She has been made whole! Come forth, little sister.”

Prime calls over Adora’s shoulder, and her every sense begins to scream; once again, there’s someone behind her.

It’s just like before, but that means—

Adora spins around, and she's greeted by a small figure dressed in white.

"C… Catra?"

"Hello, Adora."

The robotic tone. The stance. The outfit, the haircut, it's all the same and Catra is *alive* but it's still *wrong,* how did it get so wrong *again*—

"Prime!" Adora roars.

She rips her eyes from Catra's disturbingly blank face, and instead meets Prime's piercing stare. Her muscles flare to life and begin to tense as fresh anger courses through her veins.

"I've already done all of this, and I know it's a trick! I know you're… doing something to Catra, making her act like this. Why?! What do you want?"

In the beat before Prime answers, Catra breaches the line of friends and walks stiffly to Prime's side; on her way, she brushes Adora's shoulder.

The brief contact is enough for tears to form at the corners of Adora's eyes, but she does not blink; she holds Prime's gaze.

The moment Catra's taken her place, Prime states bluntly, "Oh, I believe you know what I want."

His words are punctuated by a clawed hand coming to rest on Catra's shoulder, and dread settles over Adora as she realizes the conclusion to this repetition.

No… not again…

"I… I wouldn't give up She-Ra even if I could, and you already know that. Just, please, let Catra go!"

Catra's mouth stretches into a lifeless smile.

"But I don't want to be let go, Adora. I am in Prime's light. You could join me, if you cared to. And you always did say that you cared about me. That's still true, isn't it?"

Adora nearly stumbles backward. Her eyes go wide, and her chest is tight.

"Catra, I—"

"You see, Adora?" Horde Prime cuts in. "It's a simple choice, really. Give me She-Ra, and you are free to be with your Catra. Even your friends have a place in my empire… all living things do."

Glimmer clenches her fists, anger written on her face.

"That isn't a choice! Catra would never want this, and you've turned her into a drone! You're a monster!!"

Adora's mouth has fallen open, and her breathing is shaky.

This is all my fault, and I can't stop it...

She gathers herself and holds her compacted staff with a death grip.

"Prime, I have *nothing* for you."

Prime narrows his eyes.

"Oh, but I think you do."

Adora's pulse dances wildly. This is an impossible situation all over again, and she grunts in frustration and fear. Her options have become so few, so limited.

What is happening to me?!

Adora quickly glances at Catra, then Prime, then her friends. She catches Bow's eye, and looks down at the undeployed staff in her

hands. She prays that Bow understands.

This is hardly a plan, but there's no time. She's seen what Prime can do...

He gives a small nod, and Adora knows it's the best she's got. She turns back to Prime, unsure of her every action.

Her jaw clenches.

"This ends *now.* You're never getting She-Ra."

Prime makes a disappointed noise.

"Then I have no further use for any of your friends."

His hand tightens dangerously on Catra's shoulder, and Adora yells in defiance.

"No!"

With a burst of adrenaline, she explodes forward, staff deploying and aimed right for Prime.

Prime snaps his fingers, and there's movement somewhere behind Adora.

Catra's claws extend, and there's a flash of movement in front of Adora as well. Catra robotically but quickly moves to intercept Adora's staff; Adora is ready, and ducks down and out of the way, carrying her momentum through to her strike.

Prime is right there, and even if this is all another trick, Adora won't let him touch Catra again, she *won't*—

Prime bats her staff away, and swipes a clawed hand through the air. Adora catches the blow in the abdomen, and goes flying.

A moment of suspended silence—

When she hits the ground, Adora swears she can feel something break. Her immediate instinct is to suck down huge gulps of air, feed off the adrenaline, and jump right back into the fight. But she breathes in, and her chest constricts. There's a haze over her eyes, and a ringing in her ears. Her attempt to push off the ground leaves her a collapsed mess, and she finds she can barely move.

Panic has begun to set in, and what few breaths she can manage come shorter, faster. The pounding in her head is louder than ever.

Her vision begins to clear, and from her vantage point on the ground, Adora sees Glimmer, Bow, and Entrapta, surrounded by clones. Bow has unshouldered his weapon, Glimmer is raising her fists, and Entrapta has encircled them both with her hair.

Arrows are firing, Glimmer is yelling, and Entrapta shouts, "Adora!!"

Adora finds it within herself to shout back, "Entrapta!"

Somehow, Adora has managed to hold onto her staff. With returning senses, she grips the staff as tightly as she dares and pushes herself upright. It's a struggle, but the blood and fear pumping through her are powerful motivators.

I have to get to them, I have to help…

With a mighty shove, Adora is suddenly on two feet; her entire body screams, but she ignores it. She takes as quick of a step as she can, and upon noticing her, three of the many clones turn toward her.

No…

"Adora!" Bow cries, and fires a volley of arrows at the clones. One explodes in a miniature fireball, while another falls to the ground

in an embrace of knots and rope. The third clone dodges the arrow meant for him, and then rounds on Adora.

Just as he's about to lift a powerful arm to strike, he stops dead. All the clones do, and everything falls silent for a confusing moment.

Instinctively, Adora's eyes find and meet Horde Prime's. He stares right through her, and Adora has to fight the urge to run. It's a split-second before she realizes what's happening, and follows the path from his cruel gaze down to his arm, and finally to his clawed hand. And in that hand is—

"Catra…"

Prime closes his grip around Catra's neck, but rather than crushing her, he simply lifts her up in the air.

Adora's heart stops.

Horde Prime smiles, and then with a flick of his arm, throws Catra onto the stairs that lead to the throne.

Catra's body snaps.

Adora screams.

"No!!"

Every bruise on her body is forgotten. Every ache and every half-drawn breath is left behind on the floor along with Adora's blood.

She pushes past the clone standing in her way, knocking him aside as she barrels toward Catra's body. Two more clones fall to her rampage, and in an instant she's there by Catra's side.

Slowly, gently, reverently, Adora slips her hands underneath Catra's limp form for a second time, and she begins to sob. Her anguished cries mingle with the din of a resumed struggle.

“No… Catra, no…”

Adora curls into herself, squeezing Catra tight to her chest, and she allows her eyes to close, for just one moment. She reopens them with a gasping breath, and suddenly it’s all so real.

While the numbing horror of the last hour still refuses to leave Adora's mind, it's joined now by a freshly grotesque vision. Now, she is *too* attuned to her surroundings. Now, she can feel every strand of Catra's hair under her fingers, she can hear the rough and bloody screams that could be coming from her mouth or anyone's. Now, her eyes are wide open, tears falling freely, and she can see Prime’s clones bearing down on her friends. But most of all, she is viscerally aware of how Catra's limbs are arranged, bent in ways they never should be in life.

It’s then that she feels the tickle of a thin blue glow, dancing at the edges of her skin.

There’s a rush of panic, separate from the nightmare in her arms but connected all the same.

Her heart beats faster, threatening to burst from her chest, and her breaths are rapid. The sounds of battle are louder now, she’s so aware of the bashing, the growling, and the sweat, the blood—

“No, no…” Adora mutters. “No, no no no! Not again!”

The process is impossible to stop now, and it’s siphoning once more, taking and *taking* and the glow is brighter and the pain is here too, sharp and everywhere and it’s all fire—

Adora looks around frantically, biting her tongue through the pain and trying, in these last moments, to understand what is happening to her. It’s indistinguishable from She-Ra, she knows that, and yet it’s all so different…

There’s one more tug, and her vision is reduced to a narrow cone of her immediate surroundings.

She looks up in terror, and sees Glimmer, pinned down by a clone. She sees Entrapta, struggling to remove him, the fear and desperation on her face. She watches her friends, she watches Prime's threat of violence made good in real time, and she can't possibly take any more.

A yell rips from her throat, raw and powerful.

Her hair is floating, the pain is unbearable, physical sensation escapes her body, her friends are in trouble, Catra is *fading* and—

* * *

Adora snaps into herself for the second time, and in the absence of pain comes clarity.

The screams are replaced with silence, the void of Prime's chamber with the familiar and calming flight deck of Darla.

Adora sits in the captain's seat once more, and it's all so clear to her now.

In her mind are flashes of what's just been ripped from her, taken away. She can't stop thinking about Catra's broken form, so tiny and vulnerable, and yet… her immediate surroundings are so real.

The horror does not dissipate, but the arms of her seat are solid beneath Adora's hands. The emptiness of space, just beyond that glass, is terrifyingly vast. Horde Prime's ship hangs menacingly in the distance, and Adora thinks she's beginning to understand.

That really was magic…?

She takes a shaky and experimental breath, and finds her lungs unencumbered. She remembers the pain, but can no longer feel it.

Remnants of adrenaline still in her system cause her to suddenly shoot out of her chair, and she can move freely again.

"What is…"

A million questions rush to her tongue, but there is nobody to ask, nobody to guide her. She blinks, and lets out an incredulous huff, almost a laugh. This is absurd, she can't really be back—

"Adora!" Bow's voice booms from her earpiece. "You okay? I thought I heard you say something."

Adora hesitates.

"Bow?"

"Yeah, hey! How are you doing in there?"

"I… I'm fine, I think. I… you're all out there? You're… you're safe?"

Entrapta's enthused voice squeaks, "Yes! My suits are working exactly as intended, and we are surviving in *space!!* It's so exciting…"

An image of Entrapta's terrified face flashes into Adora's mind for a fraction of a second, and she furrows her brow. If this is really happening again, then that means her friends are going to be led straight to Prime.

Her heart rate spikes. She can't let that happen to them, she *can't* —

"Alert. We are being pulled in by an outside force."

Darla's warning shocks Adora into action.

We're so close to the ship...

"G-Glimmer?" Adora asks, voice wavering.

"Yeah? What's up?"

Adora is pacing now, grinding her teeth as her mind works to put her frenzied thoughts into words. How can she possibly relay this information in the span of mere minutes?

"Glimmer, I think I… l-look, I don't have enough time to tell you what this is about, but I just—I understand now. I- I- I don't know how, or why this is happening to me, but you guys have to stay behind. Whatever… whatever's in Prime's ship, I have to face it alone. I'm going to get Catra. You guys need to stay safe."

Glimmer pauses, and then says cautiously, "I… are you sure? Adora, Prime is dangerous, and you don't have—"

"I'm sure. I'm sorry I can't explain, but I just…" Adora's voice breaks. "I can't risk losing you guys. I can't. Not for me."

There's a long silence, and then, "Okay. Normally I'd fight you on this, but… I believe you. You better not do anything stupid…"

Adora smiles weakly, and just says, "I'll try my best."

Darla shudders slightly as it lands, and Adora knows that she needs to steel herself. She grabs for her staff, back on her belt, and clenches her jaw.

Whatever happens, they'll be safe.

They'll be okay.

* * *

When Prime asks for She-Ra again, Adora is at a loss.

His claws are nearly at Catra's throat, and nothing Adora has attempted has led to a different outcome.

She’s stuck here, a familiar and deadly crossroads.

“Prime, I *can’t!* I have no magic to give, She-Ra is destroyed!”

Horde Prime hums in discontent.

“You claim to have nothing, and yet…”

The enormous crystalline display behind his throne flickers to life. On it, Adora can see images of her friends, fighting against a sea of clones. Glimmer is down on one knee, a bruise across her face. Bow is nearly out of arrows, and Entrapta is passed out, on the floor.

“No!” Adora cries.

“Your friends are still with you,” Prime continues, voice raised. “You’ve lied to me. I see all. I know all. And with this act of cowardice, you have proven that you are nothing!”

He grabs for Catra, and tears stream down Adora’s face.

“No, please!!”

Whatever I do, I can’t save them...

“I will take She-Ra from you by force, and with it, cleanse the universe of your kind’s impurity… beginning with her.”

Adora yells and charges toward Prime, but it’s no use.

Before she can even get close, Prime’s hand wraps around Catra’s neck, and he tosses her like so much dust.

She crashes into the magnificent display.

It shatters, and explodes in a shower of sparks and glass.

Catra’s body lays broken on the ground, and Adora is horrifyingly sure of what’s just happened.

This is the third time, but repetition doesn't make it hurt any less.

Adora screams as she's enveloped in sickly blue light.

Her skin is on fire, she's being drained, and with a burst of light it all fades into the past.

* * *

Darla again.

Once her breathing has returned to an even pace, Adora discovers that rather than feeling devastated, she's angry. That isn't to say the devastation isn't present; every flash of Catra's body, every glimpse of her friends in danger when she closes her eyes, cuts her to the bone, and keeps cutting.

But they also serve as fuel to the fire burning inside of her. Reality or trick, horrifying or not, Adora has had enough.

She takes a deep breath, once again surprised to find her body working flawlessly. She lets her mind work, vague ideas coming together with her anger in a swirl of determination.

Darla informs the mostly-empty cabin that the ship is being pulled in. Adora prepares herself for what comes next.

"Hey, guys? You out there?"

Bow replies, "Hey. What's up?"

"When we get onto Prime's ship, I think I have a plan. Glimmer, didn't you say that.. I thought you said Prime can see through his clones. Was that true?"

A beat, and then Glimmer replies, "Yeah, it's… it's weird. Why do you want to know?"

“I need to talk to him.”

* * *

Darla lands, and Adora is ready at the ramp. When it lowers, the group of clones is waiting for her below.

She holds her staff tighter, a poor substitution for her sword, and yells, “Now!”

Adora rushes toward her enemies, and slides down the ramp while sweeping her staff in a wide arc, taking the legs out from under the first clone. Glimmer appears behind the group, followed quickly by Bow and Entrapta; the clones are surrounded.

Adora takes on her second clone, while Glimmer finishes off her first. Bow takes aim at a fourth, hitting him directly in the neck port with an exploding trick arrow. He falls, and there’s just one left.

The clone snarls at Glimmer, taking a swipe at her. She expertly dodges, and he stumbles forward. Bow looses another arrow, this one exploding in a tangle of rope. It catches the clone right in the chest, and he’s down, incapacitated but completely conscious.

“Good job,” Adora pants. She paces towards the fallen clone, and flips him over with her foot. Immediately, he begins to rant.

“How dare you challenge the might of Horde Prime! You are nothing but the dirt beneath his boots, a speck of dust in his galaxy, foolish creatures meant for sufferi—”

His words are cut off when Entrapta reaches out her hair and wraps it firmly around the clone’s mouth, effectively silencing him. Muffled grunts are no match for Entrapta’s proudly curious voice.

“They sure are chatty! The port on their necks is particularly fascinating, I would love to study them in greater detail…”

Adora says, “If we make it out of this, you can do whatever you want. Thanks, Entrapta.”

She places a foot on the clone’s chest, and puts just a bit of weight on it. The clone’s noises fade, and she looks him directly in the eye.

“Prime? Are you watching? We need to talk.”

The clone seizes up, and shudders as his green eyes seem to roll into the back of his head. Adora’s own eyes widen in disgust.

When it’s over, the clone has bright spots in his eyes, depth and highlights and a spark that wasn’t there before, and Adora is gripped by fear. She knows these eyes.

“Adora… what an unconventional first meeting. I’ve been expecting you, but perhaps not a greeting quite this cold. I shall have my brothers escort you to me.”

“No,” Adora replies without hesitation. “I’m sick of playing your games. I need information. Something is happening to me, and I want to know why it’s happening *here.* And then, I want Catra. Whatever you’re doing to her, it ends now.”

The clone—Prime—laughs.

“You’ve come for your Catra?”

Adora bares her teeth, and pushes down harder with her foot.

“Yes! Now, can you—”

“Very well. Your Catra will be returned to you.”

Adora balks, at a loss for words. Suddenly, the process of the clone’s eyes reverses, and he’s left as he was.

Adora looks up at her friends, and the lights go out.

It's pitch black. She can't see, and immediately she calls, "Bow? Entrapta?"

"Right here, Adora."

"What's happening?"

Her question is answered by pale green lights, faint and flashing from somewhere above them. She can't identify the source, and the light pulses in a slow pattern, the darkness occasionally broken up by a split-second of sight. Even Darla's lights have been extinguished.

It's eerily quiet.

"I don't like this," Glimmer whispers from somewhere to Adora's left. "What is he doing?"

Adora isn't sure, but she knows that this spacious hangar is no place to be when it's this dark.

"I have no idea," she says, her pulse picking up. "Let's get into the hallways. Stay close to me."

Using her knowledge of the room and the precious few moments of light, Adora navigates to the front of the group, and grabs a hold of Glimmer's hand. Together, they all move forward until there's a solid and continuous wall behind their backs; here, the light splashes onto the corridor walls, and the more enclosed space provides better visibility.

"It appears to be some sort of alarm system… although what it's meant to signal, I am unsure…" Entrapta whispers. "Potential threats? Hull breaches?"

"Intruders?" Bow supplies.

Adora's heart only races faster, and she can feel something watching them. It's a familiar sensation…

"Be on the lookout. I think that Prime might try to—"

There's a rush of air directly in front of her face, and when the light flashes, there's nothing there but her friends.

Adora pushes back against the wall with more force, and gasps, "What was that?"

"I don't know, but I felt it too," Glimmer confirms.

There's another flash of light, and down the corridor, Adora swears she sees a shadow.

"There's something here!"

She extends her staff, and swivels her head as she searches for the source of the shadow.

More light, nothing.

In the darkness, more movement, and this time a yell.

"Ah!" Glimmer cries, and she collapses against the wall.

"Glimmer!" Bow shouts, and drops down by her side. "What happened?"

"My leg, I c—I can't stand," Glimmer breathes. "It's Catra."

Adora's skin crawls, and she breathes faster, shallower.

"Oh no…"

There's another burst of light, and Adora can almost make out two green eyes.

Dark again, a flash of claws, and Bow cries out.

“No!”

Adora is panicking. She doesn’t know where to go, what direction Catra is coming from. She’s normally impossible to predict, but now she’s not even in control of herself, and her deadly claws know no restraint.

Adora chooses to protect the right side, where she originally saw Catra. She holds her staff out in front of her, for all the good it will do.

I’ve never been as fast as her, how can I possibly do this?

Light flares again, and this time Adora is ready. It goes dark, and Catra swipes at her face. Adora dodges, and feels the air in front of her splitting. She swears, and then yells as fresh wounds open on her left leg.

“Ah!!”

She’s left standing, but the situation is dire.

She stumbles backward, and bumps into Entrapta. They’re back to back, and Entrapta’s frightened noises punctuate the eerie silence.

“Entrapta, are you okay?!” Adora calls.

“For now...” comes her wavering reply.

Adora is nearly hyperventilating. Her pulse pounds in her ears, and she can feel her wound begin to dampen.

There’s another flash of light, and Adora instinctively strikes out with her staff, but Catra isn’t on her side.

Adora spins around, but it’s too late.

Pitch black again—

Entrapta shouts in pain as she falls to the floor, and Adora is alone.

Chapter End Notes

The time loop fun is only just beginning.

Thank you so much for the incredible response to my previous chapter, I'm am delighted that so many people enjoyed it. Thanks for all the comments!

This fic has a Spotify playlist!

I'm aiming for chapter three to be out in a matter of weeks. As always, thank you for reading, and I'll see you next time!

still fighting

Chapter Summary

> After another failure, Adora begins to understand more about her opponent and herself.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Entrapta!!"

Adora's voice cuts a shrill line through the darkness as she whips around, terrified and disoriented. She quickly reaches out for Entrapta, feeling her crumpled form on the ground next to her.

Adora's heart rate spikes for the thousandth time in so many minutes, and she calls out, "Are you okay?!"

"I appear to be functioning…" comes Entrapta's uncharacteristically weak voice. There's a brief flash of light, and Adora can see the Princess has put on a brave face, something of a grimace. It's instantly swallowed by the stifling nothing of sightlessness.

"But Catra's claws are quite sharp… I suppose this gives me an opportunity to study her remarkable abilities from a first-hand perspective."

Adora's eyes dart around uselessly as she says with barely restrained panic, "Okay, I'm gonna move you against the wall. Just hold o—"

"Adora, behind you!" Glimmer cries.

However Adora's about to react, it's not nearly fast enough. There's a powerful strike, and she hits the ground hard. Her

already-injured leg screams in pain as an actual yell escapes her lungs.

She hears her own name in the distraught voices of her friends, ringing together into one refrain.

"Adora!!"

She sputters as she gasps for air, and shoves herself upright with a grunt of effort and the leverage of her staff. Adora's far beyond feeling the deep, *deep* scratches in her leg, viscerally aware of the responsibility she now holds on her shoulders. She shakes her head in a desperate attempt to maintain focus.

This is happening to my friends because of me, it's my fault, I can't let them die.

Amidst the pulse pounding in her head and her ragged breaths, Adora suddenly senses movement behind her.

I can't survive this, they *can't survive—*

Before she can even control it, her wavering voice shouts, "Catra, stop! Please!!"

The air stills.

With a silent flicker, the sterile illumination of the hallway returns.

In the sudden harsh light, Adora blinks. Before her is an empty corridor; in her periphery, red.

Adora's eyes go wide, she spins on her heel.

Catra's claws are frozen an inch from the tip of her nose.

Adora almost stumbles backward, but she's rooted to the spot. All she can do is gasp while her body shakes with nerves.

In contrast, Catra is a blank and unassuming slate. Unmoving, she is suspended in a swing that surely would have ended Adora's life. Her expression is unnaturally calm.

Adora stares her death in the face, and as she desperately searches those green eyes for a spark, a prayer blossoms on her lips.

"Catra? Are you in there?"

She stopped for me. She's right here and I could just grab her hand and take her away, I could—

Catra's outstretched hand suddenly retracts, and she mechanically returns to a neutral stance. A sickening crack accompanies a roll of Catra's neck, and suddenly those empty eyes shine with a cold intelligence that Adora immediately recognizes.

Two voices say in tandem, "Are you ready to cooperate?" It's a horrible amalgam of Catra's familiar tone and Prime's taunting lilt.

Adora shudders, and then calls, "P-Prime? Is that you? Get out of her head! Stop making her do this!!"

Prime smiles with Catra's lips, and says, "I'm afraid Catra is acting of her own free will. I have seen her mind, and she is so very hurt. So angry and alone…"

"Even when she was our enemy, she never did *this!"* Glimmer cries, hands pressed tightly to her wounded leg.

Catra-Prime turns their head toward Glimmer, and in response Bow slowly reaches for an arrow, the grip on his weapon tightening.

"She always did have such disdain for you," Prime drawls. "The Princess who stole away her Adora."

“That isn’t true!” Bow says. “Adora left the Horde because it was the right thing to do. Even Catra knows that.”

Catra-Prime growls, claws springing to the surface of their deadly hands.

“*Catra* is a pathetic creature, not able to process even the slightest turmoil. Bringing her into my light was an act of mercy, saving a broken soul from assured destruction.”

Adora steps forward to shout, “This is *torture.* Hurting my friends does nothing. I know it’s me you want, so just stop, please!”

“Ah yes, the almighty She-Ra…”

Catra-Prime turns toward Adora once more, claws glinting in the light. Their muscles tense and coil, and Adora braces herself.

Voice barely above a whisper, she croaks, “You know I don’t have her anymore, just, please…”

Catra-Prime narrows their eyes.

With a horrifying mix of Prime’s barely-restrained fury and Catra’s deathly calm monotone, they say, “You’re lying to protect your friends, but I see all. I know all. And I *will* take She-Ra from you.”

Adora’s eyes go wide. Prime bares Catra’s teeth in a growl, and Adora instinctively holds out her staff; it’s a mistake.

Catra-Prime lunges for Adora, and a split-second later Bow looses an arrow. It hits Catra with a snap, and she falls to the ground in the tangle of a net.

Free to move, Entrapta scrambles toward Glimmer and Bow. Adora looks at Catra, and then at Bow. He gives a quick nod, and her gaze is back on Catra in a heartbeat.

Adora limps to where she lays. Catra’s eyes are closed, her jaw clenched.

"C… Catra?"

"Incapacitated by a mere toy… this vessel tires me." Prime flicks open Catra's eyes, and looks up at Adora. "She is so very *weak.* I have no further use for her… and I will deal with you personally. Say goodbye to your precious *Catra."*

Before Adora can process his statement, Prime leaves Catra's body. The sickly green color fades, and for a brief moment, Catra's familiar mismatched eyes are visible.

Adora gasps, and sparks suddenly flash to life along the back of Catra's neck.

Catra lets out a mangled scream. She contorts in pain, sparks still flying. The energy abruptly cuts off, along with her voice.

Her eyes stare forward blankly, and her body goes limp.

Adora's mouth falls open, and she drops to her knees.

She knows.

White noise fills her ears, and she strips her throat raw with her scream.

Tears stream down her face. Adora cradles Catra's head even as she knows it can't last. A tugging in her gut comes first, followed by the unhealthy blue glow.

She sobs, a fire ignites, and it all fades into a burst of white.

***

When Adora snaps into herself, there's the requisite moment of panic; holdover pounding pulse and latent heaves of her chest spike to a new peak, and quickly begin to fade.

As always, she unwillingly calms and settles, but pushes forward nonetheless.

To avoid processing her hundredth or thousandth or millionth failure, Adora chooses instead to strategize using new information.

Clearly, seeking out Horde Prime's attention leads to disastrous consequences. In fact, she almost wonders if she had more luck in Prime's throne room, where he seemed so at ease. And yet, all she wanted from him was an answer. It was silly to think Prime would ever tell her about this anomalous hell… if he even *knew* about it.

But Adora's recent standoff in that dark hallway has given her a new focus: the purple-haired Princess of Dryl.

If anyone knows what's happening to me, it's her.

Seeing no other option, Adora chews at her lip and bounces her leg. When Darla informs her that they're being pulled in, she grips her staff with white knuckles.

***

Five clones lay on the floor, and Adora pants as she surveys her friends.

"Glimmer, Bow, I need you to stand watch. Prime might know we're here, and I need some time with Entrapta."

If Entrapta hears her name, she doesn't so much as look up from her data pad. Glimmer and Bow share a glance, before nodding in confirmation.

"You got it," Bow says.

Glimmer gives a weak smile, and together they move toward the far end of the hangar.

Left alone with Entrapta, Adora wastes no time in stating her problem.

"Entrapta, I need your help. Something's happening to me, and I can't figure out why."

Entrapta perks up, beaming.

"Ooh, what sort of 'something'? Are you referring to the fact that we're on Horde Prime's spaceship, or the possibility that Catra is still alive??"

Adora frowns.

"No, it's… it's different. I keep… I keep reliving this moment. I don't know how or why, but I've been here before."

Entrapta's eyes widen, and she's quick to pull her recorder from some previously concealed pocket.

"As a scientist, it is my responsibility to gather any data on potential space-time anomalies while in a position to observe them! As such, I would be honored to help you. Tell me everything you know!!"

Adora blinks at the recorder that's been shoved in her face.

"Uh… well… t-this is the fifth time. The first time we did this, we all charged in. Glimmer led us to Horde Prime's throne room, and things… I mean… they didn't go well. He…"

She hesitates, not wanting to say it out loud. A part of her is still worried that acknowledging it will make it true. She takes a shaky breath, and stares down at the floor.

"Prime killed Catra."

The recorder retreats slightly, and Adora looks up just enough to see that the smile has faded from Entrapta's face.

"I… see…" comes her stilted and quiet voice.

Adora is touched by this display of tenderness, as simple as it may be, and she knows she needs to push through the rest of her story.

"Catra's not… well… the thing is, after she was… that's when it happened to me. Some sort of light, this feeling like I was being drained, like my skin was on fire. I think I was glowing? It reminded me of transforming into She-Ra but it—but it wasn't like that at *all* and I just… before I knew it, everything had gone back to how it was before. We were all on Darla. It was like I'd never even left."

Entrapta lights up again, unable to fight back her curiosity.

"Fascinating…" she coos. "And Catra was alive, after everything reset?"

"Yes."

Entrapta just paces, absorbing this new information.

"Hmm, and you've clearly retained this memory, while we, the other crew members, have not… Could it be a localized phenomenon, specific to this ship?? Perhaps Horde Prime possesses a powerful portal machine far more advanced than any that Etheria can produce… it would surely account for some sort of altered state, though I haven't detected any such anomalies in my limited observation. And the magic… hmm. This has happened multiple times, you say?"

Adora nods, saying, "Yes. Each time, we approached Prime differently, and each time, Catra… didn't make it. But I remember each one, and they all ended with that draining feeling. I just want to know what's *happening* to me, so I can stop it and—"

“It must be She-Ra!” Entrapta states simply.

Adora just blinks, and can’t help it when a small laugh bubbles up in her throat.

“You really think so? I just… why? Why would She-Ra do… any of this, when I can’t even control it?”

“I don’t know!” Entrapta exclaims. “That’s the wonderful thing about magic, it’s so *unpredictable!* But it was certainly She-Ra in that cave, so why not now? Your account does seem to line up with my observations about She-Ra’s magic, so perhaps this is a defense mechanism!”

Adora sighs, and says, “Defense from *what?* This is awful, I’ve had to watch the most terrible things happen to someone I… I just think I’d know if this was She-Ra. This has to be—”

“Did you know about accessing She-Ra without the sword?”

Adora stops mid-sentence, mouth hanging open.

“No, I didn’t,” she says, her mind stormy with bad memories. “The First Ones were controlling She-Ra, not me. I guess… I guess there’s a lot of things I don’t know.”

“And isn’t that beautiful?!” Entrapta shouts, startling Adora from her dark thoughts. “Not knowing things is a part of life! But that just means that there’s always something new to learn.”

Entrapta gazes at Adora with a happy, curious smile. It’s a far cry from the pained grimace Adora had seen just minutes earlier.

“I… I hadn’t thought of it that way.”

Entrapta’s smile widens.

“Well now you have! And as for what this is a defense from, I have a hypothesis based on my years of research! She-Ra’s magic has always been particularly susceptible to your emotional state.

With the sword no longer controlling you, I suspect that your emotions may be manifesting through your magic with renewed focus… In the cave, it appears you were able to access She-Ra when your friends were in danger, and now, I believe you are being given a second chance!" Entrapta quickly glances down at her tracker pad, and corrects, "Or, ah, a fifth chance!"

Adora hears the words, but can't muster a response.

This is happening because Catra is…

Entrapta takes a step forward, and places a purple-haired hand on Adora's shoulder.

In a small voice, she says, "My hypothesis is that you are not able to live in a world without Catra."

Gray eyes fill with tears, and Adora fights to hold her composure.

"I…"

It's a whispered fragment and it dies on her lips. Images of Catra dance through Adora's mind, smiling and laughing and warm; angry, too, flashes of Catra snarling and fierce and hurt but *alive,* so real that Adora could reach out and touch her.

Instead, she blinks away tears and takes a steadying breath.

"I didn't know She-Ra… I didn't know *I* could do something like that."

Voice full of awe, Entrapta says, "She-Ra is the largest and most powerful source of magic that we currently know of besides Etheria itself! Without the restriction of the sword, I suspect that you may be capable of magical feats that haven't been known about for millennia. Think of the data we could collect…"

Adora reflects on that. She-Ra was always powerful, but the ability to completely alter time is *certainly* beyond the scope of her

experience… especially since the only trigger seems to be Catra's death.

Adora has the dreadful feeling it won't stop until something changes.

"You're right, we could definitely learn some things," Adora agrees. "And let's say… let's say She-Ra is messing with time somehow, resetting all of this because of Catra. How do I… how can I stop it?"

"I don't know!" Entrapta says. "Though the reason we're here in the first place *is* to rescue Catra, and she seems to be the key to all of this. If you succeed in saving her, perhaps there would no longer be a reason for She-Ra's defense mechanism to activate!"

Adora frowns, but doesn't counter Entrapta's suggestion; she knows the Princess is right.

"That's what I was afraid of. None of this will end until I get Prime to let her go. And he's *awful,* he wants She-Ra more than anything and he just… it's like he knows what I'm going to *do* and he's *everywhere,* these clones and and this ship and I just—"

She cuts herself off, and heaves a sigh.

"I guess I'll just have to keep trying. I don't have any other choice."

"Okay!" Entrapta chirps offhandedly. "In the meantime, I do think we should observe what we can… Glimmer mentioned a server room, perhaps Horde Prime has weaknesses we can exploit."

Adora suddenly realizes that Entrapta has reached the end of her expertise. This is a purely magical matter—and an uncharted one at that. Entrapta has offered what help she can, and despite the lingering frustration of being trapped in this loop, Adora is grateful to the purple-haired Princess. She decides it's time to press forward.

Besides, Adora thinks bitterly, *in an hour, Entrapta won't even remember this conv—*

She shakes her head slightly.

No. I don't know that for sure.

Adora focuses instead on Entrapta's words and nods, attempting to envision a future after Catra has been rescued. The reality is that they'll need to know more about Horde Prime, one way or another.

"Yeah, I remember that Glimmer talked about a server room. Maybe… maybe we can learn how to take Prime down. Would you be able to access the servers, if we can get you there?"

Entrapta practically glows, and if Adora didn't know any better, she'd say the Princess had a runestone all her own.

"I can certainly try!!" Entrapta exclaims.

Despite her situation, Adora smiles fondly.

"Good. And thank you, Entrapta. I think I know what to do now."

***

Instinct tells Adora that splitting up is the wrong thing to do, but instinct means so little in the face of the new and the strange. With her failures fresh in her mind and a sliver of hope on the horizon, Adora finds herself open to a change of plan.

The group pairs off. Entrapta and Bow will investigate the server room, while Adora and Glimmer go after Catra.

Adora doesn't tell Bow and Entrapta that they might be better off this way.

***

Adora and her Queen glide through the halls with practiced precision. At the predictable sight of patrolling clones, the duo ducks behind a pillar.

"Why are we skipping the cell?" Glimmer whispers.

"I just… I have a feeling that Prime did something to Catra. I think getting to his throne room is the best bet."

Glimmer looks grave.

"Okay. The last time I saw her, Catra was… in a tough spot. Let's hope she's alright."

Adora nods even as images of Catra's corpse flash into her mind.

"Yeah… let's move."

As they resume their mission, Adora puts a hand to her ear and asks, "Bow, Entrapta, any luck?"

"Not yet," Bow replies. "These hallways are tough to navigate, especially when everything looks the same."

Glimmer chimes in, "Look for a room with a lot of glowing tech in it. It'll stand out, and that's got to be the server."

"Then that's our access point!" Entrapta trills.

Adora says, "Alright, just… stay safe."

"You too."

The comm line goes silent, and Adora finds herself that much more relaxed. The assurance of communication and the fact that

her friends are farther from danger is a much-needed shot in the arm.

So far, so good, she thinks, not yet sure if she believes it.

The identical hallways are no match for Adora's experience, and a series of memorized turns soon brings them face-to-face with the huge entrance to Prime's throne room. The two clones guarding the doorway bare their teeth when they take notice of the intruders, and Adora rushes forward. The air hums; there's a jolt in her arms as her staff makes contact, a grunt from Glimmer as her fist connects, the din of bodies crumpling to the floor. Breathing only slightly harder, the girls stand victorious.

"That was a great move, Adora! You're really getting good with that staff."

Momentarily forgetting the situation, Adora allows a smile to creep onto her face.

"Yeah, well, all that Horde training never really goes away. I gotta be good for something besides magic swords, right?"

Glimmer matches Adora's expression, and replies, "I dunno, *Horde scum.* Think you can keep up with a non-magical Princess?"

Adora almost chuckles, but stops herself just short. This sort of banter, she realizes, hasn't really happened for over a year. They've been too… busy.

"Yeah, I think so. Are you ready to face Prime again?" It's a question to herself as much as Glimmer.

The Queen's smile fades, and her jaw sets. She nods, and Adora nods back.

"Then let's go."

A clone's hand dissolves the green energy in the doorway, and then it's the sickeningly familiar walkway, the yawning pit below.

There’s no echo of footsteps.

Adora’s heartbeat nearly drowns out her thoughts.

She glances at Glimmer, and the other girl is shaking slightly.

Adora reaches out her hand. Glimmer, eyes ahead, grasps it tightly in her own.

“Prime’s chipped Catra,” Adora finds herself muttering. “She’ll be under his control. She’ll attack us if we make a wrong move.”

Glimmers whispers, “How do y—”

“Just trust me. Prime’s going to try to provoke us, and he’s looking for an excuse to take us out. I’m going to tell him I don’t have She-Ra anymore. Stay calm, and play along.”

Glimmer says nothing, but hesitantly squeezes Adora’s hand.

Adora hopes desperately that dropping the games is a way to move forward. Prime is proud, and he demands truth. The least she can do is provide it, sans aggression.

I’ll be careful this time, she tells herself. *No more mistakes.*

They reach the platform, and find Horde Prime totally alone. He lounges on his throne, piercing eyes already on them.

At the sight of him, Adora feels a spike of fear. She wants to grip her staff for reassurance, but it’s collapsed and hooked to her belt in an attempt to project cooperation. Instead, she squeezes Glimmer’s hand once more, and drops it as they ascend the steps.

The duo comes to a stop about fifteen feet from Prime, and he regards them, opaque and unreadable. Adora hasn’t seen this expression before, though whether that’s good or bad, she isn’t sure.

Nobody says a word, and Adora’s skin crawls. Glimmer fidgets.

“Ah, Adora,” Prime finally says. “How good of you to join me. I’ve heard so very much, it’s a pleasure to finally meet you. And you’ve brought Queen Glimmer, an honor as always.”

Adora blinks and throws a glance in Glimmer’s direction.

“Horde Prime. I hear you’ve been looking for me.”

“Indeed. Your friends were kind enough to inform me that you are the almighty *She-Ra.* I simply had to see it for myself. Such a familiar name…”

“Well, I’m here now. And I think I know what you’re going to ask of me.”

Prime narrows all four of his eyes.

“Oh?”

Adora nods, as calm as she can be.

“Yes. I know you seek She-Ra’s power, and I know you’ve been told that only She-Ra can access the weapon that lies at the heart of Etheria.”

Horde Prime looks through her.

“That is correct. Your tone would suggest that you are opposed to such a thing… but I am not unreasonable. Why don’t we make a deal?” He rises from his throne, and calls, “Come forward, little sister.”

Adora knows what will follow, but attempts to delay the inevitable; she’s rooted to the spot, and won’t turn around. Glimmer, though, gasps softly next to her.

“...Catra?”

Adora feels that horrible sensation of being watched, and finally turns.

Catra stands before her, blank as ever and not quite alive.

"Hello, Adora."

Adora pushes down the urge to run to Catra, willing herself to stay in control. Catra walks to Horde Prime's side, and Adora meets her tormentor with fiery eyes.

"What… what are you proposing?"

Prime smiles serenely, and places a hand on Catra's shoulder.

"A trade. I will let you have your Catra, provided you give me She-Ra."

Adora clenches her jaw, worried that her next move will torpedo the undeniable progress she's made.

"I… I can't do that."

Prime's grip on Catra tightens, and Adora rushes to explain.

"I can't make the trade, because I'm not She-Ra anymore. The sword that allowed me to access She-Ra's powers, the sword that the First Ones left for me… I broke it, months ago. There is no She-Ra anymore. The weapon at the heart of the planet was destroyed along with her. There's no power to take. If you're as reasonable as you claim, you'll know I have nothing to bargain with. All I—all I want is to protect the people I care about."

To Adora's surprise, Prime laughs. She flinches, the noise running over her like knives.

An uncomfortable moment passes, until Prime finally ceases his performance, opening his eyes and pinning Adora with a dangerous stare.

"Forgive me," Prime says, artificial mirth still lacing his timbre. "The weapon, destroyed? A clever falsehood, but a falsehood nonetheless. When I detected the energy signature of your

planet, it was far beyond anything I have seen in millennia. You could not destroy it, She-Ra or not. A foolish bluff."

Glimmer curses under her breath, and Adora can feel herself beginning to sweat. She can't let this fall apart, not again…

She takes a hesitant step forward, terror written on her face.

"Prime, look… I know what you've done to Catra. I know what you intend to do with us, with our planet. But there really is nothing for you. Please, just… let us take Catra home, and we will *never* bother you again."

It's a last-ditch effort. If Prime has seen through her plans, then there's nothing left to lose.

Nothing except…

"Catra?" Prime inquires. "You do not know Catra. You cannot know what I have done for her. I am afraid that you never knew her at all. Just as you have lied to me about the weapon, you have lied to Catra… a promise broken."

Adora blurts, "No, that's not—"

"I have seen her mind!" Prime suddenly shouts. "I have granted her peace, something which you could never do. You are a worthless creature, and whether or not you still possess She-Ra's power, I will take it from you by force."

Adora's eyes go wide, and Prime takes a step backward.

"Little sister, show them my light."

Catra's claws extend, and Adora instinctively reaches for the staff on her belt.

"Adora?" Glimmer asks, shaky. "What are we going to—"

Catra interrupts by surging forward, and Adora internally swears.

No no no!! This isn't right—

She dodges Catra's first swing, and Glimmer leaps out of harm's way. Catra turns on Adora, and jumps into a powerful attack.

Adora sidesteps, and when Catra lands, Adora collapses her staff and tackles her opponent.

They tumble head over tail, before coming to rest in a rough embrace a few feet from Glimmer.

"Catra!" Adora pleads. "I know you're in there! Snap out of it!"

Distantly, Prime's laughter echoes. Catra grins, and simply says, "Oh, Adora. But I'm right here."

Adora dodges another deadly swipe, but stays tangled in Catra's limbs. Tears in her eyes, she grabs fistfuls of the strange material adorning Catra.

She takes a breath to invoke their broken promise, when Glimmer calls, "Adora!"

Adora's head snaps up, and clones are surrounding them. Glimmer's fists are up and her eyes are fierce, but Adora knows it's only a matter of time before she's overwhelmed.

Beneath her, Catra cackles.

"What's the matter, Adora? Just give in to Prime's light. We could be happy together."

Adora's lungs are now working overtime, and she glances from Catra to Glimmer and then back again.

"Catra…" she manages to say.

Glimmer grunts with effort as a powerful punch takes down a clone; another takes his place.

Prime's chuckle once again reaches Adora's ears, and her eyes find him in an instant. He's standing by his throne, amusement splashed across his hideous features.

Adora feels Catra under her fingers, maddeningly close and dangerously taut. Glimmer struggles nearby, and Adora knows what she has to do.

"I'm sorry!" she gasps, releasing her hold on Catra and standing up swiftly. For a moment, Catra almost looks surprised. It hardly registers, and Adora's gone.

She rushes toward Prime, staff extended once again.

His head is thrown back in laughter, and he's distracted.

She's gaining speed, a killing blow at the ready.

He can't see her, this is her chance, a yell escapes her just as she's a foot from him and—

There's a sickening noise as Adora's staff connects with Prime's neck. The attack elicits a bellowing roar, and Prime falls to his knees.

Adora is shocked to see the fruit of her labor materialize, and instinct takes over as her foot shoots out in a kick. Prime's jaw gives way and he collapses, face against the ground.

He lets out a strangled exclamation, but before he can move again Adora grips her staff tightly.

With a cry, she plunges it down into his neck.

All movement stops, and for a split second, it's silent.

Green liquid gushes from the wound, fatal and final and disgusting.

Adora lets out a shuddering breath, and it's like every clone has turned to see their brother's demise.

She basks in the silence, and drinks in the moment.

Prime is gone. It's over.

Remembering herself, Adora quickly glances at Catra; her eyes are still green, and Adora frowns. Her gaze shoots instead to Glimmer, who stands in a sea of clones, panting and looking at Adora with confusion.

"Is he dead?" she calls.

Adora nods absently.

"Yes. It worked. I—"

She's cut off by a sudden movement as the clone closest to Glimmer and Catra begins to twitch.

He seizes up, and a shudder rolls through him as his eyes shine with familiar life.

Across the throne room, the clone meets Adora's gaze.

Horde Prime smiles.

He reaches out a hand, and Adora is sprinting and yelling even as she knows what will happen.

"Don't touch her! Leave Catra alo—"

But it isn't Catra that he reaches for.

A strong hand grips the front of Glimmer's shirt, and Prime lifts her off her feet.

Adora's blood runs cold.

Glimmer screams and struggles against her opponent, but she’s just out of reach and he’s far too powerful.

Prime takes a purposeful step to the edge of the platform.

Adora pushes herself and she’s almost there, but she’s not going to make it, *she won’t make it and—*

Prime lets go, and Glimmer falls.

Adora’s heart stops.

She’s too stunned to move.

The last thing she sees before screaming and fire overtake her is a small patch of sparkles.

They glow faintly where Glimmer had just been, the last attempt at magic by a non-magical Princess.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you for waiting so patiently for this chapter! Between meeting the cast of the show, holidays, and catching Covid (ugh) it's been slow going for my writing. But, as you can see, this story is far from over! Thanks for reading, and rest assured that chapter 4 is on the way!
>
> As always, comments and feedback keep me going! I'll see you all next chapter!

when i spoke to you last

Chapter Summary

> As Adora begins to break, old wounds reopen. A ghost is laid to rest.

Chapter Notes

> We could all use some healing. Enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It's a long time before Adora finds herself again. That, or it's a matter of seconds.

She blinks away tears, and cautiously works her diaphragm. Air moves to fill her lungs, and it doesn't even sting; her throat should be stripped raw.

She looks around, and it's the same as ever. She's sitting in the captain's seat, aboard Darla's flight deck.

The images register, but her brain is elsewhere.

In her mind's eye, Adora sees a winged goddess looking over her immortal shoulder.

She hears a last request, and knows that she's failed to uphold it.

I can't even take care of myself.

How can I take care of them, too?

It's a question that doesn't have an answer. Adora's hands make fists, her body's only recourse.

Mercifully, comm chatter cuts through Adora's shock and brings her fully into the present.

“Adora? You alright?”

Adora’s eyes go wide as she recognizes Glimmer’s voice. She opens her mouth to respond, but produces only a single word.

“I…”

Bow mistakes her hesitation for nerves, and chimes in, “Hey, it’s alright. We’re with you, no matter what.”

Dully, a distant part of Adora appreciates Bow’s constant kindness. She collects herself as best as she can, and responds weakly, “Thanks, Bow. And yeah. I’m… I’m alright.”

“Good!” Glimmer practically sings, a smile in her words. “We are *so* gonna kick Horde Prime’s ass.”

Adora frowns slightly, but says nothing. A beat later, a shudder rolls through the ship and saves her from more conversation; they’re about to land.

As if on a timer, Darla says, “Alert. We are being pulled in by an outside force.”

Adora grits her teeth and stands up, fumbling for her staff. She’s glad to give her hands something to do. She marches to the boarding ramp and begins to pace, working out her nerves and impatiently waiting for her enemies.

Darla shudders again, and comes to a stop. The doors slide open, and Adora doesn’t waste even a second. She tears from the ship, feet clanking against the metal of the ramp. With a yell, she launches herself into the air and comes down hard on the first clone.

The others step back, and she sweeps her staff in a wide arc, rushing through to the predictable outcome. A jab to the neck here, a kick to the face there, and the clones are out cold.

She hardly registers what she's done, and it isn't until Entrapta cackles that Adora realizes her friends are standing behind her.

"You're very efficient at incapacitating clones, Adora! All of that combat experience sure would make for valuable data…"

Adora turns around to respond, but Bow beats her to the punch.

"Entrapta's right, you really did a number on these guys. Good job, Adora!"

Glimmer steps forward and asks, "So, what's the plan?"

Adora can't meet Glimmer's eyes, and turns instead to Bow and Entrapta.

"I… Entrapta, Horde Prime has a server room on board. I think if we can access that, we might be able to learn more about how to take him down. Can… can you do that?"

"I certainly can! I'm already picking up a *biiiiiig* signal!"

Adora nods.

"Good. Bow, can you go with her?"

"Of course. What will you two be doing?"

Adora says hesitantly, "We'll be—"

"We'll be going after Catra!" Glimmer interrupts. "We know where her cell is, and we know Prime's up to something. We should be able to take care of it. Right, Adora?"

"I… yeah."

"Okay, sounds like a plan," Bow says. "Promise me you'll stay safe?"

"Promise," Glimmer and Adora say in harmony; only Glimmer's voice reaches Adora's ears, her own affirmation drowned out like

every other promise she's made.

Bow seems satisfied, and gives them both a nod.

"Alright. We'll stay in touch with the comms. See you soon."

He joins the Princess of Dryl at the edge of the hangar, and unslings his weapon from his shoulder. Entrapta looks up from her data pad and beams at Adora and Glimmer. Her hair gives a wave, and the pair disappears into the maze of corridors.

Quiet briefly settles over Adora's mind, a much-needed reprieve. She catches her breath. It all comes crashing back down when Glimmer begins to chatter.

"Okay Adora, we'd better move. There are clones everywhere, and I don't know what they did to Catra. We should—"

"I need you to stay here."

Silence.

"What?"

Adora dares to look Glimmer in the eyes.

"This is… it's going to be dangerous. I know where to go, and I can't risk anything happening to you. Not ag—I just can't. Please, Glimmer. Stay safe, for me."

Glimmer gives a tiny laugh, clearly not fully understanding.

"Oh c'mon, Adora. If this wasn't dangerous, it wouldn't be us. I'm going with you, and that's th—"

"No. Glimmer, no. Trust me on this, Prime is—"

"Prime is what? Evil? Scary? I know, *I'm* the one who's faced him before. I know this plan is reckless, Adora, but I'm staying with you. I have to help save her. She could have died for me, I *have* to do this."

Adora grits her teeth.

"Glimmer, you *don't* understand. This is—it's complicated. But trust me when I say that it's better if you stay behind."

At that, Glimmer's face drops.

"Oh, is it?"

"No, no I don't mean—"

"No, what *do* you mean? We've gone over this, I will *not* be the queen who stays behind. Not anym—"

"I HAVE TO KEEP YOU SAFE!!" Adora roars.

Glimmer's expression hardens.

"NONE of us are safe until we get off this ship. *Catra* isn't safe! What do you think we're doing?? This isn't Etheria anymore, Adora. This is the universe, and it's not safe for *anyone."*

"Angella told me to—"

"STOP IT! Don't talk to me about what my mother wanted. She's not even here anymore, but *I* am."

Adora sighs, the sound of exasperation and exhaustion. She makes a split-second decision, and grips her staff with white knuckles.

"Prime doesn't care about any of that, Glimmer. He won't hesitate. He never has before. I'm going to confront him, and I'm going alone."

She holds Glimmer's gaze for one more electric moment, before breaking it off and heading for the halls.

"W-wait a second, hold on," Glimmer's voice calls after her. Adora doesn't turn around.

“What do you mean, ‘he never has before?’ You haven’t even faced him yet. And where are you going?? We have to go to Catra’s cell, she’s—”

“She’s not in there, Glimmer! I’ve done this before, and I am *telling* you, Prime has her.”

Glimmer has now fully caught up to Adora, glued to her side as Adora traces the path she knows all too well.

“Wh… what do you mean? Adora, can you just tell me what’s—”

Adora scoffs.

“Of course I can’t tell you. Would you even listen anyway?”

“Why wouldn’t I listen?! It’s all I want. I’m right here and I want to know what’s happening. The *Queen* want to kn—”

“Oh, give me a break!” Adora chuckles. “Don’t pull that again.”

Adora knows it’s easier this way, when she doesn’t have to see Glimmer’s face. Even still, the wounds reopen like they had never scabbed over.

“I thought we were past this! I thought we trusted each other again.”

“Did we trust each other again?? Because we didn’t really deal with it, Glimmer. I came all the way out here for you, and I’d do it again in a heartbeat. I know you said you're sorry, and I know I said it was okay, but have we actually *talked* about it? Are you ready to face that??”

“Adora, I *am* sorry, I just—I didn’t—”

Glimmer’s stumbled words are interrupted by a pair of patrolling clones, who freeze momentarily when they spot the intruders. They rush forward, and Adora seizes the opportunity to exercise

her aggression. She growls and leaps toward her enemies without a second thought, while Glimmer protests to no avail.

"Adora, we have to be caref—"

"—know what I'm doi—"

"—get us both killed!"

At Glimmer's last word, Adora flinches. The clone in her path makes good use of her hesitation and sidesteps, swiping at Adora with a clawed hand. He connects, and Adora cries out in pain.

"Adora!!"

Glimmer rushes to Adora's side and swings wildly at the clone. Her movements are messy, and the clone catches her fist in his. He twists sharply, and Glimmer is on the floor next to her friend.

Adora yells in frustration. Nothing is going the way she hoped, and Glimmer is fighting *her* as much as she is the clones.

"Glimmer, I told you to stay behind!"

"I—ungh—won't leave you!"

Adora would scoff again, but she doesn't have the luxury. She quickly rolls out of the way of the second clone's attack, and leaps to her feet.

"Work with me here! Back of the neck!" Adora slashes her staff in a wide arc, and catches both the clones in the chest; they fly through the air and crash to the ground. "You've got to hit them!"

Glimmer scrambles to her feet and starts to sprint, growling as she turns her burst of speed into a devastating kick aimed right at the neck of the nearest clone. He lets out a strangled yell, and promptly falls unconscious.

Adora pants, and turns to the second clone. He's rising to his feet, but before he can fully recover, Adora rushes to his side and bashes her staff into his neck port. He collapses, and Adora's side burns in agony.

"Gahhh! I can't believe he got me…"

She sucks down insufficient breaths, and leans against her staff. Glimmer joins her in pyrrhic triumph and falls back onto the wall, lungs bursting and shoulders slumped.

They regard each other like wounded animals.

As Adora acclimates to the pain, she can feel the distance between her and Glimmer widen into a chasm. She shouldn't be mad anymore. Glimmer is here—Glimmer is safe!—and days ago that was all that mattered.

But Adora's entire life has suddenly been upended by the magic she should be controlling. She's stuck here, reliving the same handful of moments. She's barely holding it together, just trying to make it through without another death on her hands.

She's bitter. And it's a foreign feeling.

The pain has been blunted, and Adora knows they have to move. She pushes off of her staff, and mutters, "Let's go."

Glimmer follows without another word.

It's only two hallways later that they arrive at the doorway to Adora's fate. There are clones here, too, but before Adora can muster the strength to attack, Glimmer rushes forward with white knuckles.

She throws a punch, and the first clone doubles over. He receives a kick to the face, and with a *crack* he's on the floor. Adora moves in to help, and just in time; the second clone roars and charges at Glimmer, who's too slow to fully dodge the attack. She yelps at his

glancing blow, and Adora takes advantage of the clone's recovery. A hit to the neck, and he joins his brother.

The girls pant in unison, and Adora silently grabs for a clone's hand, pressing it to the force field. It disappears, and Adora looks back at Glimmer. She's wincing at a bruise on her arm, but looks up and nods.

The pair begins their trek to Prime's throne.

As they cross the walkway, Glimmer breathes a little harder, a little faster. Adora knows it's because of this room, and she gives her best approximation of reassurance as she whispers, "Just… let me do the talking. You don't have to go through this again. I won't make you. It's me he wants, so keep quiet. It… It'll be okay."

"How do you know?"

Adora bites her tongue.

She doesn't respond.

Before long, they reach Prime's platform, only to discover that his throne is facing the massive view screen.

Adora leaves Glimmer's side and strides forward, calling, "Prime. I'm here."

The throne rotates, and Horde Prime reveals himself. As usual, he lounges with a smirk on his face.

"Ah, Adora. I heard you coming, I wondered when you'd arrive." He turns his attention to Glimmer, and adds, "And the Queen!

How good it is to see you again, your majesty."

Adora's far too tired for strategy, and she says flatly, "Where's Catra? And don't play games, I know she's here."

Prime bows his head in mock gentility.

"But of course, *She-Ra.* You must be so worried about your Catra. You shall have her. Come forth, little sister."

There's a familiar presence behind Adora, and the entire world narrows. She knows what happens next, and hesitates before turning. Glimmer gasps, and Adora winces as she reluctantly turns toward her undoing.

Catra is as blank as ever. Adora's heart bleeds at the sight.

"Hello, Adora. Hello, Glimmer. Have you come to bask in Prime's light?"

Adora frowns. Catra's dead words are somehow fresh, and she's reacting to the shifting environment around her. This new information sends a rush of extra adrenaline into Adora's gut.

Catra's still in there… somewhere.

"What did you do to her?" Adora asks, involuntarily. She curses the fact that she actually wants the answer; her morbid curiosity is too strong, and a simmering, patient part of herself needs to know exactly how Prime has reduced Catra to this… shell.

To Adora's surprise, Catra answers for herself.

"Prime has given me freedom from the woes of this world. Pain, anger… *heartbreak.* His light has taken all of that away, and my mind is clearer than it's ever been. You could join me, you know."

Catra holds out a delicate hand and gives a warped vision of an inviting smile; Adora is surprised to see that the invitation is not for her.

Catra stares through Glimmer instead, and the Princess' mouth has fallen open in horror. Adora's eyes dart back and forth between the pair, and she wills Glimmer not to respond. It doesn't work.

"Ca… Catra?"

It's a whisper, but it's all Catra needs. She takes a step closer to Glimmer, and smiles even wider.

"Your worries about Etheria, about your friends… they could all be washed clean, if you would only take my hand. I know you feel such guilt about the Heart, but he could take that away, too. All beings are equal when molded into His image."

"You have *no* idea what I—"

Glimmer stops herself. She's moved forward a pace, and there's rage in stance. She looks quickly to Adora, who stares back with hard eyes.

Adora spits, "Don't do anything. It's not really her."

Prime chuckles, and Adora's focus breaks.

"Of course it is her, you little fool. I've simply given her peace. Not that either of you would know about that. The Queen prepared to end a life… and the girl who shattered her promises. Catra has suffered so much at the hands of you both. It would be a mercy to take that all away… to take *She-Ra* away."

Glimmer shouts, "You don't know anything about her!"

Adora is stunned for the second time in as many time loops.

Glimmer is still willing to defend Catra, even after everything…

"I know *exactly* what she's been through!" Glimmer continues. "I thought I was connecting with her, but now look! You stripped it all away. That's not Catra anymore!"

Adora finds herself again, and hisses, “Glimmer! He’s not going to __”

“Interesting,” Horde Prime interrupts. “You think that your emotions are a strength? How typical of you.”

Prime takes a step forward, and he towers over them. The room darkens.

“Believe me, your majesty. I’ve looked into the deepest corners of Catra’s mind, and the *connection* that you cling to so tightly is little more than the mutual terror unique to mortals. You are a failure, exactly like her. You are *nothing,* creatures scrounging at the fringes of your tiny world for scraps of power. I know about your dirty deeds, Glimmer. I know what Catra has done. Between the two of you, the universe was almost ripped apart twice over. It’s clear that the power of your planet is better off without you.”

Adora can feel a pounding in her head. She knows these words. They are prophets of destruction, the signal of her defeat before she’s even started.

“You’re right,” Adora blurts. Prime narrows all four of his eyes.

“Etheria is unstable. The power isn’t just better off without them, it’s better off without anyone. It’s ancient, and it hasn’t exactly weathered the years. One wrong move, and the planet will go up.”

She can’t keep the edge of panic from her voice; she’s bluffing, but only just. She’s not sure what Prime’s tampering might do, and the threat of catastrophe is real enough to throw into his face. It’s a desperate plea, but Adora’s completely out of options.

“I-it’s true,” Glimmer says with a wobbling voice, quick to catch on.

Prime says nothing, and lurches from his towering position to stalk past the pair. He comes to rest beside Catra, and places his hand on her neck in an all-too familiar warning. He examines Glimmer and Adora.

Suddenly, he barks a short and lifeless laugh.

"You're telling the truth, aren't you? Oh, that *is* amusing. Etheria, ever the thorn in my side, is a ready-made bomb."

Adora begins to sweat.

That's not what she meant to convey.

"T-there's no telling what will happen if you try to harness it. No matter what you do, Etheria—"

"—Will be cleansed," Prime says, all humor drained from his voice. "How could I pass up an opportunity so perfect? And really, I should thank you, Adora. You and the Queen are such apt representatives of your planet. Your Catra"—he brushes a claw along her skin— "even moreso. You are weak, squabbling amongst yourselves and causing devastation in your wake. Etheria must burn. You've made this too easy."

Adora sends a glance toward Glimmer, the only thing she can do without hyperventilating. This is disaster. This is apocalypse.

It doesn't matter what she does.

Prime will win.

And Adora will lose.

She wonders, idly, if she could simply snatch Catra out of Prime's grip and *run.*

"I…"

Her voice croaks. She has nothing left, and another loop is gone.

Prime tightens his grip on Catra. He holds the power, and he's watching them squirm.

Adora seriously considers bolting.

Beside her, Glimmer's body is taut. They're both prepared for something, but only Adora knows what Prime is about to do.

There's no way to communicate with Glimmer.

I can't do this, I can't watch it again, I can't I can't I can't I ca—

It's Glimmer who moves first.

She lunges toward Catra, and Adora fruitlessly yells, "No!!"

Catra ducks out of the way, Glimmer stumbles.

Adora rushes forward, but it's too late.

Prime has a hold of Catra again.

He's laughing.

Glimmer recovers, and looks back just in time to see Catra's broken body hit the floor.

Adora does not scream.

Her face does not contort in anguish.

But the noise in her skull is deafening.

She catches fire.

It's sick, like always. A pale blue glow, that drains and takes and warps. It burns, a power that scalds and sears her skin. Adora lacks even the energy to react. She simply grits her teeth against the crushing pain, and waits for the magic to claim her.

Before that can happen, a voice tears through Adora's internal screaming.

It's Glimmer, sobbing and calling Catra's name.

Adora lets herself look at her, this version of someone that will cease to exist in mere moments, and Glimmer looks back.

Blue light is reflected in her dark and watery eyes, and she gasps, "She-Ra?"

Adora still doesn't respond, can't possibly respond. Glimmer watches her blank face in horror, and in her last moment, Adora's bottom lip trembles.

The pressure is unbearable, tears spill down her cheeks, and the fire engulfs her.

***

Adora screams only when she is alone.

Of course, she no longer has a reason to scream; her pain is gone, her body is refreshed, and everything has been reset.

All the same, her anguished voice rings out into Darla's cabin, but rather than echo and fester, it gently fades away and is replaced by the quiet hum of the ship.

She takes deliberate and deep breaths, until slowly, patiently, her heart rate evens out.

After a few moments she reaches up to wipe the damp from her cheeks, but finds her eyes dry. She blinks, and focuses on her surroundings. She needs to ground herself.

Adora takes in Darla's console, the familiar tech of the First Ones, and the vastness of space just above that. It's her view every time she resets, and something about it is beginning to feel like home.

The thought is strangely relaxing, and she feels her eyes unfocus. The stars blur into opaque nothings, and she's met instead with a pale white shine. She furrows her brow, and looks closer at the glow. It's coming from the glass, except it isn't; Adora rises from her seat and steps forward, only to discover that the glow moves toward her at the same rate.

It's a reflection.

Adora gasps, and looks down at her hands. Sure enough, her skin shimmers with energy.

"D-Darla, dim the viewscreen."

"Affirmative."

The glass goes dark and glossy, and Adora can see herself clearly. The light is concentrated around her head, tiny sparks and fountains of brilliance dancing like a halo and playing over her temples.

"Magic?" Adora asks out loud. "But I'm not… nobody is…"

She trails off as she studies the pattern of the glow. It moves in gentle pulses, so unlike the sharp and forceful fire of the other magic.

The other magic…

She curses herself for being so distracted.

We're going to land soon, and I have to save Catra. I have to do it all over again…

Adora thinks back to Prime's throne room, desperate for any new information, anything that she learned. It's only when she probes her mind for the details that she realizes: she can't actually remember.

Or… she *can* remember. She remembers Glimmer's defense of Catra, and the terror of knowing Prime had won yet again. She thinks back a loop, and recalls Glimmer's fate. A loop beyond that, and it starts to become fuzzy. Even the memories she's managed to conjure of the recent loops are soft, like the brush strokes of a painting.

She can remember her past experiences, but the edges have been dulled, somehow. And this sensation, this magic… it's *right.* It's magic as she knows it, the familiar, comforting warmth of She-Ra.

"She-Ra…"

Adora examines her reflection once more, and finds that the glow is emanating from her core, and her chest. It's exactly like—

"Healing! I'm healing myself! But… can I heal… minds?"

The question hangs in the air, unanswered. All Adora knows is that she feels lighter, freer.

She marvels at herself with wide eyes. Finally, she blinks, and the glow disappears.

Adora is alone once more.

Darla silently restores the glass to its original state, displaying the void of space. Adora watches.

With measured movements, she returns to the pilot's seat. It's solid and reassuring beneath her.

As she settles, Bow's voice crackles to life in her ear.

"Hey. Just wanted to update you, we're coming up on Horde Prime's ship. Are you still good to go?"

Adora attempts to respond, but her voice comes out as a weak splutter. She coughs, swallows hard, and says, "Sorry, I just… Yeah, I—I'm ready. Thanks, Bow."

"You got it. We're with you, all the way."

Adora breathes deeply, and thinks of Glimmer.

Darla's console flashes red, and her flat voice announces that the ship is being pulled in. Adora waits a moment, and then rises from her seat. She hovers near the ramp.

Darla lands. The ramp extends. Adora prepares herself for more clones.

When she sees them, she's not nearly as angry, but she still dispatches them quickly, as if her body is moving for her.

When her friends drop from the hull of the ship, she thinks she might actually be ready to face them.

She focuses first on Entrapta and Bow, and repeats her request: find the server room, collect any information on Horde Prime's weaknesses, and come back in one piece.

Entrapta giggles with delight, and Bow assures her they can do it.

He steps forward for a brief hug, and Adora's never needed it more; he's warm, and he's safe. She gives her thanks, and says they'll keep in touch with the comms.

The pair say their goodbyes, and disappear into the labyrinth.

Adora waits a beat, and then faces Glimmer.

The Queen’s eyes sparkle with determination.

Something inside of Adora threatens to collapse all over again, but she pushes through and gives voice to her healing heart.

“Do you… do you want to talk about it?”

Glimmer blinks, caught off guard.

After a moment, she says softly, “Yeah. We can talk about it.”

Adora nods. She collects her thoughts.

“I… know why you did it. Or wanted to do it. Because this is… well, it’s kind of awful, isn’t it? Prime, and l-losing She-Ra. The Heart seemed like a good choice. I get it.”

Glimmer takes a swift step forward and bursts, “But I shouldn’t have, I know that now!”

“Glimmer, we all made mi—"

“But it was *so* stupid of me, Adora, and I’m sorry. I spent every second on this ship regretting it, but you still came for me, and I —”

“Well, of course I did!” Adora snorts, a smile threatening to show on her face. “I wasn’t just gonna *leave* you. And do you think Bow could stay away?”

Tears shine on Glimmer’s cheek.

“But he—he was so mad at me, and you—I thought—”

“Yeah, he was frustrated. And… so was I. But Glimmer, you’re our friend. That’s never gonna change.”

Glimmer pauses, and looks at the ground. When she speaks again, her voice is small.

“I’m so sorry, Adora. Activating the Heart was wrong. And like I said with Bow, you have… *every* right to be mad at me. It was so stupid. I just… I wanted to help. I’m sorry, Adora.”

“I’m not mad at you Glimmer. Not anymore. I just… it’s been tough. Coming here and saving Catra… it’s been in my head. I keep playing out these scenarios. Repeating different ways this could go down. And I keep getting worried. I mean, with you here…”

It all hits Adora at once. The weight of this conversation. The weight of closure, the last strain of the heart before freedom.

Glimmer gently prompts, “Yeah?”

Adora’s composure is crumbling rapidly, but she steels herself and forges ahead.

No turning back.

"I—I know I've told you about Angella's last words to me. But I don't know if I really said how much they meant. Ever since the portal, I’ve been *living* for those words. *I'm supposed to take care of you,* Glimmer. And making you come back here, knowing you might get hurt again… it's so difficult to ask that. It worries me so much. I can't… I can’t lose you again.”

Glimmer gives a small, melancholy smile, and watches with glistening eyes. Adora's shaking now. Her voice is wavering and it's taking everything she has just to keep her bottom lip steady. She pushes forward, on the brink.

"You and Bow are my whole world. A-and this mission is such a bad idea, I mean, I don't even know if we can save Catra! I've gone through it and I *don't* think I can do this alone and it's so hard to admit that I need h-help, and I—"

She falls. Her knees meet the metal of the floor and she sobs.

"Oh, Adora… I've got you…"

Glimmer's arms are around her in an instant.

"It's okay, I've got you. I'm not letting go…"

Adora lets herself cry.

It's different now.

This time, she's not crying over a body.

This time, it's freeing.

These tears are far older than the loops, far more bitter than her recent screams. It hurts to let them go, yet it's the only way forward.

And it is utterly comforting.

Glimmer rocks her gently, whispering assurances and sweet words.

Adora rides out the wave of tears, until finally the flow is stemmed.

She lifts herself from Glimmer's embrace, and the two sit on the floor of the ship.

They regard each other, best friends again and always.

It's Glimmer who speaks first.

"We'll be okay, Adora. We're gonna save Catra, and we're gonna do it *together."*

A beat.

"And… I'm sorry for—for blaming you. For mom."

Adora draws in a breath, slow and steady.

"Glimmer, I…"

"She might not be here, but I know what she would think. She would be so proud of you, Adora."

"You… you think so?"

"She *was* proud of you. She told me."

"I—wow. She really said that?"

Glimmer sits up straighter and clasps her hands in front of her. In a higher, more regal tone, she says, "'That girl is brave. She's a fighter, like you. And she's come a long way from the confused Horde soldier she once was. I'm so proud of her.'"

"Angella said—"

"Yeah, she did. And I think you've done a pretty good job with the whole 'taking care' of us thing. I'm still here, right? So is Bow, and everyone else. Taking care of each other doesn't just mean you, you know."

"I… I know. It's hard to remember that, sometimes. And Catra—"

"—is going to be fine. I haven't given up on her, and I wouldn't *dare* suggest that you have either. I know she's… special."

Glimmer stands up, dusting herself off. She gazes down at Adora, and extends her hand.

"So what do you say? Wanna go get her?"

Adora huffs once in an imitation of a chuckle, and says, "Well, we're already here, aren't we?"

She takes a hold of Glimmer's hand, and she's hauled to her feet.

"Besides, I think I might actually have… a plan."

Glimmer raises an eyebrow.

"Oh?"

Adora nods.

This is the moment of truth; she needs Glimmer to stay safe, but asking her to stay behind is clearly not an option.

Adora has, of course, been strategizing. She wonders if she ever really stops.

Each loop is an echo of another, and she's experienced enough of them to know that whatever this is, it's not time travel. It's a literal resetting of time, circumstance, decisions, and bodies. The loops twist and vary, and each one is unique. Were it truly time travel, the exact same decisions would lead to the exact same outcomes. But with this kind of variance…

I can't account for everything.

Not by myself.

Adora looks at Glimmer.

"Yeah. I *do* have a plan. Do you trust me?"

"You know I do."

“Okay. Then we need to split up.”

“...Alright. That’s weird, but… I’m guessing you have a reason?”

Adora nods quickly, and says, “Yes! After what happened, Catra could be anywhere. She might be in a cell, or she could be somewhere else, being… I don’t know, tortured, or something. I’m not assuming the worst, but I think we should be prepared. Can I ask you to go to the cell? You know your way there, and if Catra’s still in there, she’ll need you.”

Glimmer’s eyes dart around the room as she silently absorbs the information. Eventually, she says, “Okay, that… that makes sense. And where will you be?”

“I’m going straight to Horde Prime. Catra could also be with him, and… I’m the one he’s looking for. Between the four of us, I know we can find Catra. Plus, we can stay in touch with the comms.”

Glimmer nods, looking more confident.

“I like that plan. I just… I want to help, Adora.”

“I know. And that’s why I’m trusting you with this. I don’t know exactly what you went through together, but you and Catra seem… closer. Just the way you talk about her.” She smiles suddenly, and teases, “Don’t tell me you like her. I think that’s my job.”

Glimmer flushes slightly and says, “I—I don’t! But… we had a chance to talk, and she’s really just scared. She’s scared like we are, and… she deserves to come home.”

“I think you’re right. Thank you, Glimmer. Thank you…”

Glimmer sighs, heavy and exaggerated. “You and Catra… you two are *ridiculous.*” She shakes her head gently, and then grins. “The others have a head start, wanna catch up?”

“Let’s do it.”

The pair walks to the maze of hallways, stopping together at the first intersection.

Adora doesn’t waste any time, and pulls Glimmer into a hug. Glimmer hugs right back, holding her best friend tight.

Adora is nearly crushed under the pressure, and yet she feels lighter than ever.

When they separate, they each have tears in their eyes.

There’s nothing left to say, except—

“Stay safe.”

“You too, Adora.”

The girls share one last smile, turn, and head in opposite directions.

Chapter End Notes

> Whew, this one took a long time to write. I'm very proud of this chapter, and I hope it was as satisfying to read as it was for me to create. Things are bad right now, but I want to reiterate that the point of this story has always been hope, even in the face of darkness and despair.
>
> Never stop fighting, never give up.
>
> I love you all.
>
> See you next time!

all i wanted was you

Chapter Summary

> Adora throws herself into her task with more determination than ever, but is forced to make a decision that could destroy the only chance she has to save Catra.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As one wound heals, another opens.

Catra's claws slash through the air, and Adora is a fraction of a second too slow; her staff catches, ripping from her hands and flying into the abyss. Adora cries out in frustration.

"Agh! Catra, please, you don't have to do this…"

Catra laughs mechanically, but doesn't stop her assault.

Everything has gone terribly wrong, again. Adora almost isn't even surprised. Feeling confident from her talk with Glimmer, Adora had reached Horde Prime with an inflated sense of ability, but the most she'd gotten out of her slight emotional reprieve was a weird sort truce with Prime: he had forestalled any outright action in favor of siccing Catra on her and watching them fight. She doesn't know what she said to make it happen, but it's one awful step in the right direction.

What *isn't* a step in the right direction is the fact that she's losing the fight. Without She-Ra, it was bound to happen. Catra is better than she is, and always has been. Faster, deadlier, any combination of words that are complimentary, Catra probably has it over Adora. Adora barely sidesteps another attack, and she's on her back foot.

The fight has taken them up onto the raised platform, and Adora is being cornered by Prime's throne and the huge, intricate viewscreen situated behind it. She needs to buy some time, and she needs to do it fast.

"Catra! Just—just listen to me, I know you're in there!"

Catra twitches, but doesn't stop her advance. "Of course I'm here, Adora. I am simply at peace."

Adora is panicking now. Desperate, she feints to the left. Catra is swift in her retaliation, but overcommits, lacking the finer control her body normally possesses. Adora pulls back and goes right, while Catra stumbles forward into the exact spot Adora was just standing. For the first time in the entire fight, Adora is left with a tactical advantage, which will vanish in an instant unless she acts.

Without a second thought, Adora charges forward.

There's a suspended, quiet moment as her body collides with Catra's, rushing toward the glass, until—the noise. The display shatters with a deafening ring as Catra and Adora crash through it together, locked in an aggressive embrace. Shards rain down around them, and Adora is numb to the fresh cuts and scratches lining her face.

A beat passes as the girls struggle to get up. Adora hopes to whoever's listening that the shock was enough to break Catra free of her brainwashing. She rolls onto her side, groaning, and pushes against the cold floor. She searches for Catra fruitlessly.

"Catra? Catra, are you okay?"

No response. Adora is sitting up now, and scrambles to her feet. She whips around, looking for any sign of her friend.

She was in my arms… Where did she go?!

A sharp *snap* to Adora's right gets her attention, and her search is over. Catra stands, bruised and bloody, with a particularly jagged

piece of glass clutched tightly in her torn-up hand. She stares blankly. Adora gasps, fresh urgency in her tired limbs.

"Catra! Whatever you're about to do, please, just wait. I want to talk."

Catra steps closer, totally unphased. "We don't have anything to talk about, Adora. I want you to join me, but you're so stubborn. You always were headstrong."

Despite her words, Catra falters. There's a sparking on the back of her neck, and her green eyes flash back to yellow and blue.

There she is!

"Catra!"

But the moment is brief: Catra returns to a horribly neutral state, and it's as if it never happened.

Adora pants, feeling lost. Her eyes are flying back and forth, looking for anything that can be used, anything that can be done. She settles on reaching for her own piece of glass to counter Catra's weapon, and it's a tactical error like no other; she darts forward, but her movements are sloppy from the bruising. One foot comes down on a larger, glossier shard along with all of her weight, and she falls to the ground once more. Her ankle makes a noise that it never should, and she can't move it no matter how much she struggles.

"Ahhh… No! No, no, no…."

Catra is feet away.

I can't move I can't move I'm going to die I'm going to d—

Catra is smiling.

This is it I'm a failure I'm going to die—

Adora crawls like her life depends on it, pulling herself nearly two meters, and it takes all her strength. It's not enough.

Catra bears down on her and grabs a fistful of Adora's hair, yanking out her ponytail and bringing her up to eye-level. Adora flails and screams, a stream of pleading and pain, even managing to land a punch on Catra; Catra is unaffected.

Amidst all the noise, Catra leans in close.

"It's easier this way, my love. You'll be in Prime's light soon."

Adora's entire world stops in a flash: unbelievable agony pierces her side. The pain in her scalp is instantly eclipsed, all the air is driven from her lungs, and she can't even gasp in surprise. She looks down to see the shard of glass planted deep in her side. Red tints her vision.

"N-no…" she croaks. "C—Catr—"

Her pitiful protests are cut off as Prime's laugh echoes around the enormous chamber.

"Oh, Adora," Prime coos, stepping into the chaotic scene with hands clasped neatly behind him. "You *are* in a bind, aren't you? I have enjoyed watching you… resolve your issues."

"Go to—to hell," Adora splutters, voice weak. She ignores the fire coursing through her veins and the horrible wetness of the floor and continues pulling herself forward. An inch here, an inch there. She needs to reach Catra. *She can still reach her.*

"It's fascinating, is it not?" Prime opines. "Bitter enemies… and yet the two of you can never seem to stay away from each other, can you?"

There's another spark on Catra's neck, and another flash of blue and gold; Catra—*really* Catra—looks at Adora for the briefest moment.

In a small, scared, familiar voice, Catra asks, "Adora?"

And she's gone once more, green-eyed and blank. Adora gasps at the revelation, then growls in frustration. It becomes a choking, gurgling cough and she spits up blood.

Prime takes no heed, continuing in his freakishly calm voice. "You used to talk of ruling the world together, up on that little spot on the roof that only you knew about."

Adora stops in shock, or at least as much as she can muster in her broken state. "How did you… what did—"

"Then you *left,"* Prime adds sharply. "You broke her heart."

"No! No…" Adora wheezes. She squirms with her last reserves of energy, but the movement only serves to push the dagger of glass deeper into her side. Her vision is beginning to darken, and she can't get enough air with her shallow, rattling breaths. "Ah…"

Prime steps closer, kneeling down between Adora and Catra. He looks into Adora's deadening eyes. "You always wanted more… but all she ever wanted was you."

Adora screams without making a sound. Her body is numb, no breath can be drawn, and her blood boils as everything falls away.

She's dying, and she can do nothing to stop it.

The lack of air reaches her throat, thick and heavy, and she begins to choke. Catra is so close… *Adora* is so close, just an arm's length away from her goal, but it's meaningless now.

Prime smiles, and whispers, "Goodbye, *She-Ra."*

Adora lets out one last, fighting hiss of air, and slumps into merciful unconsciousness.

Unbeknownst to her, her body begins to glow.

Time resets.

***

Adora grabs her staff and wastes no time returning to Prime's throne room. She plays to Prime's ego, once again managing to avoid a direct confrontation, instead being relegated to the role of Catra's plaything.

She tries another tactic, keeping her distance rather than trying to keep up, landing blows on Catra's exposed neck whenever possible. It works for a time, but eventually Adora has to contend with Catra's claws.

Her staff can't protect her, and a slash to her thigh leaves her in a pool of slick blood, immobile once more and at the mercy of Prime.

She says the wrong thing.

Catra's body crumples in a shower of sparks.

Adora bursts into flame.

***

Prime talks, Catra appears, and Adora bides her time. All she needs is for their pacing and circling to take them toward the center of the platform and the raised section that holds Prime's throne.

They're off to the right when Adora makes her move; just as before, she feints and forces Catra to overcommit. She steps out

of harm's way, and tackles Catra with all her might. She's aiming for something this time, hoping desperately that Catra's neck makes contact with the sharp edge of the stairs.

There's a horrible noise, a crackle of sparks, and stillness.

"Catra? Are you in there?"

Blue and gold eyes.

"Adora? Is that y—"

More sparks, and Catra stops moving.

***

Adora can't keep her mouth shut, and Prime crushes Catra with his bare hands.

It's almost like the old days.

Adora sobs as she is transported into the past.

***

She fights her way to the throne room. She fails.

***

She fails again.

***

And again.

***

And again.

***

And again.

***

Her staff is ripped from her hands. Catra is ripped from her life. She's failed *again.*

***

It's no use.

***

It's no use.

***

I can't do this.

***

It isn't possible to save her.

***

I can't watch her die again… I can't lose her anymore.

***

Adora is ready to give up when she sees Catra's real eyes. It's been a few loops since she's gotten even that. It's a small reprieve, but it's what she needs to finally think clearly.

Adora hardens herself and makes a tough decision.

She's so tired.

***

Adora is on Darla's deck, the start of every loop and the end of every failure.

Despite the variance of each attempt, they all begin the same: Adora reaches for her staff, and she fights her way to Catra. Healed memories ease the burden, but no plan or tool or change in circumstance has ever helped her achieve her goal. She can't memorize her way out of this. There's no perfect path, no right answer to study. She holds her staff now, running a finger over the cool metal etching. Not even this weapon, steadfast and constant, has allowed her to win. Adora bites the inside of her cheek.

She takes a breath, and then another, and finally a third, filling up her lungs and preparing herself for the biggest shift in strategy yet; it could be the most disastrous decision she's ever made, but then, what does she have to lose?

"Hey, guys?" Adora ventures.

"What's up?" Bow responds.

Adora hesitates.

Glimmer prompts, "Adora? What's wrong? We're getting closer to the Prime's ship, are you—"

"I'm changing the plan," Adora states firmly. "I can't keep… I have to try something, and I need you all to trust me. When we land, I'm… I'm giving myself up. No more fighting. Catra will be—she'll

be fine. I have important jobs for each of you. Would you be willing to go along with this? For me?”

There’s silence on the other end for several seconds, until Glimmer’s voice finally crackles to life. “Yeah, we can do that. Whatever you need.”

“We’re with you, Adora!” Entrapta says.

Adora breathes a sigh of relief.

“Thank you so much... *Thank you.* I’ll explain the plan in a moment. I love you guys…”

Adora switches off her comm, and wipes away the tears forming in her eyes. There will be time for that later, but for now, she has a job to do.

She looks down at the staff, still clutched tightly in her hand.

She loosens her grip, allowing it to slide through her fingers until it touches the ground. She leans it up against a wall, freeing her hands and letting herself be truly alone for the first time in recent memory. She feels smaller, defenseless, but she knows it has to happen.

She paces to the captain’s chair and sits. She switches the comm back on.

“Alright,” she says, voice clear and determined. “Here’s the plan.”

Chapter End Notes

> Been a while, huh? Sorry I haven't updated, I've been hard at work on another fic (Muscle Memory, check it out!) and also dealing with some life changes. I hope you enjoyed the sweet, sweet pain, and that you're ready for more!
>
> Chapter 6—the final, super-sized, and definitive version of Save the Cat—will be posted two weeks from now, on

Wednesday, September 13th! See you then, and thanks for sticking around for more than a year <3

you matter to me

Chapter Summary

> Adora gambles it all on a risky strategy and winds up with the best opportunity she's ever gotten to save Catra.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Alert. We are being pulled in by an outside force."

Adora narrows her eyes and hopes it's the last time she'll ever have to hear that phrase.

When Darla lands, dozens and dozens of repetitions are thrown out the window: every instinct Adora has is telling her to ambush the clones, to battle her way to Prime, but she pushes them down and sticks to her plan. When the ramp lowers into the hangar she walks out with her hands up. The clones restrain her, and she suppresses a laugh at the absurdity of the reversal. It manifests as a tired, cocky smile instead.

"You won't find anything, I came alone," Adora says. "I hear Horde Prime's been looking for me. Figured it was time we met."

The lead clone stares at her blankly until deadpanning, "Yes, you *will* be brought before Prime. And there you will receive your judgment."

Adora's captors gracelessly shove past her and they're off, walking toward familiar hallways.

A half a minute later, Adora's earpiece buzzes with Bow's voice. "We're in. They didn't find us."

Thank the stars.

"Good," Adora whispers in reply. "Be quick, and don't get caught." She continues her journey, one thought on repeat in her mind: *take me to Catra, take me to Catra, take me to Catra.*

Glimmer pops back onto the comms. "Okay, everyone, sound off. I'm heading to Horde Prime's holding cell to get Catra."

If she's there, Adora thinks.

Bow says, "And Entrapta and I are gonna hack into the ship's server and download any intel about Prime's weak points."

"Look for a room with a lot of glowing tech in it," Glimmer responds. "I remember them taking me past it when—when they took me to… That has to be the server."

Entrapta babbles in response, but Adora catches on Glimmer's hesitant voice. It occurs to her that she doesn't know what, exactly, Glimmer experienced on this ship, but the anxiety evident in her tone is suggestive enough.

The chatter comes to a close, and Adora hurriedly whispers, "Okay, uh—everyone just be careful." Glimmer's fear has lent an edge to Adora's already riled nerves, and suddenly the flaws in her plan rear their head; she ignores them and marches on.

When the emerald force field looms, Adora knows they've reached Prime's chambers. Without so much as a stern look, the field dissipates and the clones grant her access, simple as can be. It feels wrong, unearned.

"You will go alone," the lead clone tells her.

Bow, supportive as always, chirps, "You got this, Adora. Keep him talking."

Glimmer scoffs. "Knowing him, that is *not* going to be a problem." The joke is simple, but it's a fresh interaction that Adora hasn't heard before. It draws out the smallest smile, a reprieve before the toughest part of the plan.

The chasm of Prime's throne room yawns before her, and she wonders, not for the first time, what lies at the bottom. She traverses the walkway as a thin sheen of sweat forms on her brow.

This is it.

After an agonizing eternity Adora reaches the platform, where Prime is obscured by two of his lackeys.

Adora's voice is hard and sure as she calls, "Prime."

The clones part to reveal Horde Prime, resting on his throne, veins green and bulging. Adora grimaces, but keeps her eyes ahead.

"Welcome, Adora."

There's a pause as the clones poke and prod the various tubes, and Adora stares at the horrible, squelching liquid that must be Prime's synthetic blood.

"Would you believe that we're the… inspectors?" Bow says, tinny and small in her comm. A scuffle breaks out and the noise turns to static nothing. Adora has no idea what her friends have just gotten themselves into, but she can only hope they're coping.

"Forgive my unseemly state," Prime finally drawls. "It is a tedious task, but a necessary one to maintain this vessel."

Adora has no patience for whatever ritual Prime is performing in this loop, whether it's a stalling tactic or a failed attempt at intimidation. Her right hand forms a fist, itching for the solid mass of her staff and instead grasping at air.

She states, "This is how it's going to go. We're gonna make a deal: you're gonna give me Catra, and then you're gonna let me leave again, free and clear. I have something you want, a weapon that only She-Ra can activate: the Heart of Etheria. And if you don't do as I say, then I'll use it, and destroy you and your empire, for good."

It’s an incredible bluff, one she never would have tried making in her first loop. She doubts her own words as soon as they’ve left her mouth, cursing her inability to act.

Prime doesn’t seem to notice, and throws his head back in laughter.

“Is… is something funny?” she ventures.

Please be his stupid ego, he can’t resist a challenge, please please please…

Prime recovers from his fake—or is it genuine?—chuckle and says, amused, “You are not going to use the weapon, or you would have already done so! You would never risk the safety of your… Catra.”

This is good. He’s confident, but relaxed.

“You don’t know me,” Adora counters. “And you don’t know what I’m capable of.”

Prime loses the smirk and growls, “Oh, but I *do.”*

He disconnects from the menagerie of wiring and rises to his impressive height, affecting his innocent, simpering voice once more. “I am old, far older than you can imagine. My brothers lend me their life force, and when one vessel fails me, I simply elect another. Thus, Prime has reigned eternal through the centuries.”

Prime begins stalking toward Adora; he extends a clawed hand, grabs her chin, tilting her head to and fro. She gasps at the intrusion, but stands her ground.

“There is something *so* familiar about you, Adora. A face I have not seen in a thousand years. Not since I faced your ancestors and crushed their once-mighty empire beneath my heel. You call them the First Ones. And you are one of them, are you not, Adora?”

Adora's eyes go wide and she breathes faster, heavier. Prime has never talked of the First Ones, shown no indication that he was even aware of them. The revelation that Prime might have been the source of their extinction ripples through her.

"I thought the First Ones were all gone," Prime continues, "but clearly some faction remains. That race of tyrants abandoned you on a forgotten planet in a shadow dimension. They made you their weapon, their *She-Ra."*

This information is mercifully stale, and Adora has already made peace with the circumstances of her arrival on Etheria. In her mind's eye she sees flashes of Light Hope, of the magic of the Heart. She sees Mara; she sees the sword in pieces. She tenses her jaw and defends herself. "I don't fight for the First Ones. I fight for my home, for myself, and for my friends. Now for the last time: where is Catra?"

"Adora?"

Catra's shaky voice echoes around the chamber, and Adora suppresses her shock. It's Catra—*not chipped,* but really her. Adora loses her cool and spins on her heel.

"Catra?! Where are you?"

"Of course," Prime interrupts. "Your Catra. She hoped you would come for her, poor thing. So all I had to do was wait. As she would have said, 'You are so very predictable.' Come here, child."

Adora watches, frozen, as Catra steps up and onto the platform. She's hooded, flanked by two clones, and she stands for a static moment before reaching up to reveal her awful, blank face.

"Hello, Adora."

Experience hasn't made it any easier to see Catra like this; Adora lunges forward—is intercepted by the clones—her voice straining as she yells, "What did you do to her?!" She already knows. She refuses to accept it.

Catra shows no signs of recognition, moving with unnerving precision up to Prime's dais where she prostrates herself.

"I have made her anew," Prime answers. "I saw her mind, so ensnared in rage, and grief, and pain, and I brought her to the light." As he speaks, Catra stands and accepts Prime's overly-familiar gestures, his would-be parental touches. "Isn't that right, little sister?"

Adora's stomach churns. She barks, "Catra, you have to fight it!" The sooner she can introduce the idea of rebellion, the sooner that the tiny, tiny spark still inside of Catra can ignite, or so she hopes.

Catra responds distantly, disappointingly, "My place is with Horde Prime, Adora. I don't want to leave."

Adora grits her teeth. *I hate this, I hate this so much…*

"Tell her what I've done for you," Prime gloats.

Catra paces forward until she's close, *dangerously* close, saying "Prime has given me peace. Something you could never do." Catra raises a hand and places it gently on Adora's cheek, prompting a spike in heart rate that's completely instinctual, uncontrollable.

"You broke my heart," Catra says, voice almost soft and intimate. "But he has made it whole again. Don't you see? This is for the best. I'm happy here."

And then, in a display more frustrating than any that have come before, Catra tilts her head slightly, as if for a kiss. Adora's eyes flick down the Catra's lips; she's lost count of how many times she's wanted this, but not now, not here, not like *this*—

"I'm happy here," Catra almost purrs. "You could be happy, too."

There's a stream of tears on Adora's cheek, a flare of anger when Prime moves to take Catra away.

"Let her *go.*"

Prime's hand lingers on Catra's neck, and the situation is suddenly rigged to explode. Adora holds her tongue to avoid the consequences she knows are just one wrong word away.

"Shall we make a deal, Adora? I will give her to you, if you want her. But first, you must do something for me. You will give me She-Ra."

Adora knows that refusal won't end well, but things are new, unpredictable, and granting his impossible request will lead to failure all the same. She makes a calculated risk and speaks clearly, angrily.

"Never."

"Very well."

Prime raises his hand, and Adora's heart sinks.

Wrong choice. He's gonna kill her again, he's gonna do it and I have to watch and—

Prime snaps his fingers and Adora's comm whines in her ear, crackling as it shorts out. She gasps in pain, ripping it out and dropping to her knees. Prime is there to crush the piece of electronics with his boot, stepping forward with a snarl.

"You miscalculated. I see all. I *know* all. You thought yourself worthy to challenge me, but you are nothing but a false hero, the last of the First Ones to fall at my hands." Prime tightens his grip on Catra, and it's all too familiar. "You have led your friends to destruction."

But there's a flash of Catra's eyes, blue and yellow, something that's never happened this early or in a situation this dire. Adora looks up and inhales sharply.

She's still in there!

"Go on, fulfill your purpose," Prime prods. "Bring out She-Ra and strike me down."

Adora barely hears his taunts, seeing only Catra through her teary eyes.

"Ah… But you two must have a lot of catching up to do."

What? "I will leave you to it. Let me know when you're ready to make a deal." Prime sweeps past Adora, meets his two clones, and leaves the platform. Adora blinks.

What… is this?

Suddenly, she's alone with Catra. Adora turns to face her former friend, not sure how to tackle this unexpected development. Catra's claws extend, and Adora's muscles feel the fatigue of loops past.

Adora hastily squares up, and Catra launches herself forward. Adora dodges, but isn't prepared for the second strike, a punch to her jaw that leaves her reeling. She recovers, ducks underneath a third strike, and scrambles for her bearings.

She's behind Catra, but the advantage is gone in an instant when Catra turns and kicks. Adora yelps, does her best to grab Catra's leg, but is brought down to the ground in a swift and brilliant move.

Before she can even catch her breath Catra's fist is pounding into the metal next to her head. Adora kicks, but Catra grabs a handful of blonde hair. It feels eerily similar to the last loop, and Adora thanks the stars that there's no glass strewn about, waiting to be plunged into vulnerable flesh.

Her thoughts shatter when Catra's razor-sharp claws head right for Adora's face. With a grunt she pulls aside, and suddenly Catra's arm is exposed, caught.

There's a moment's reprieve as Adora restrains her opponent, and she hurriedly says, "Catra, listen to me. I know you're still in there. I'm *not* leaving without you."

Catra laughs.

Adora says, more to herself than to Catra, "It's gonna be okay."

Catra's response is worse than any words: her arm twists and writhes within Adora's grasp, producing a chilling *crackcrunchcreak.* With muscle and bone no longer a barrier, Catra subtly shifts within Adora's restraint. Her advantage becomes sickeningly clear when her good arm slashes across Adora's thigh, eliciting a cry of pain and reversing the situation all in one instant; Catra is free to slip behind Adora, wrapping her arms around the other girl's chest in a horrifying inversion of an embrace.

"Everything is already okay," Catra says into Adora's ear. "We are with Prime now. There is no need for you to suffer, Adora." The words are followed by an almost gentle caress, and Adora's heart rate spikes.

When Catra adds, "Come into the light with me," something snaps. Adora's tears and shaky breaths are converted to frustration and adrenaline. She reaches behind her, yells, pulls Catra off of her like a sword from a sheath, and tosses her onto the hard ground. There's a dull *clang* of deformed metal and then a more mechanical noise as the chip on Catra's neck slams into the corner of Prime's raised platform. It isn't a consequence Adora had intended, but her heart leaps at the outcome all the same when Catra chuckles, sounding closer than ever to herself.

"Snap out of it, Catra! I don't wanna hurt you!"

The chuckle tapers off; a sharp jawline and disheveled hair are on full display, almost seductive, almost a taunt.

"But you have already hurt me," Catra says, voice low. "Prime has set me free of that pain…"—she stands—"the pain that *you* caused." Catra ascends the stairs backward, holding her arms out

to the side as she says, “He will set us all free, forever. A world of peace without end.”

The words hang in the air, and all Adora can do is witness Catra in her elevated position, a look of faux-serenity plastered across her features. Adora’s eyes dampen with tears. She takes a breath, and —

What follows is a rapid-fire sequence: Catra leaps into the air, rearing for an impossibly fast strike. Adora pulls back just in time, and instinctually throws out a punch. It connects, she’s immediately horrified, and it shows on her face. Catra is vulnerable now like she’s never been before, and Adora can’t bring herself to fight her loved one. She absorbs an equally devastating punch thrown back in response, dodges deadly claws, and takes both of Catra’s arms in her hands. They grapple, faces mere inches apart, and Adora pushes away to afford herself valuable space. Catra stumbles backward instead, and suddenly she’s teetering on the edge of the unknowable void.

“Catra!” Adora reaches out her hand, but doesn’t dare make a move.

Catra turns her head to examine the chasm below, and laughs once more while taking a deliberate step backward. Adora yelps and launches herself forward, catching Catra just as she begins to tip. She pulls Catra into herself, her breaths escaping as pathetic whimpers of relief.

The relief is short lived: Catra’s claws shred through cloth and skin, sinking right into Adora’s back. Catra speaks, and this time her voice is mingled with Prime’s.

“Oh, Adora. How long will you drag this out? You will destroy the ones you love in the process.”

Catra-Prime disentangles themself from a crying Adora, and looks her in the eye before planting a knee squarely into Adora’s abdomen. Adora doubles over, and as she struggles not to wretch,

Catra-Prime grabs a fistful of her collar and dangles her over the edge.

What should I do? What should I do, what should I do, what should I—

"She was afraid in the end," Catra-Prime says. "And she suffered." They examine their claws idly. "Perhaps I will make her my new vessel… though she would not last me long. What do you think, Adora?"

Adora's non-existent patience does nothing to stop her from rising to the provocation, and she screams while driving forward, taking Catra with her. They stop only when they slam into Prime's glass viewscreen, which leaves Catra's chip sparking and stuttering. For one shining moment, Catra's real eyes are visible again. It's another unexpected victory; Adora gladly receives it.

A rumbling shakes its way through Prime's ship, and Adora examines the ceiling before turning her attention back to Catra.

"I am *not* giving up on you, Catra!"

The viewscreen sparks and flickers along with the lights.

"Then you're a fool. You cannot stop Horde Prime. He will reign triumphant over all the universe. It is… destiny."

The exact moment Catra says the last word, a tendril of electricity shoots from the damaged viewscreen and connects with the chip.

Catra cries out in pain, and Adora roars, "No!" She takes Catra in her arms, and the glass emits a high-pitched whine as it fills to bursting with unregulated power. Adora pulls Catra to safety just as each panel cracks, and a second later the whole thing explodes in a brilliant, deafening display. Catra and Adora are blasted off their feet, landing several meters away in a pile of glass and each other. Her hair has come loose, and hangs around her in limp, singed strands. It's too much like last time, except… except—

The chip crackles and splutters.

Blue and yellow eyes open slowly, cautiously.

She's here she's really here it's her it's her—

Catra takes a shaky breath, and speaks in her own lovely, beautiful, perfect voice.

"Adora… you should have stayed away. Why did you come back? We both know I don't matter."

Adora rests a hand on Catra's cheek and says, voice cracking, "You matter to me!"

Catra's eyes well with tears, and she gives the smallest, weakest smile before the blankness of the chip overtakes her again. She slaps Adora off of her and sits up, stumbling over to the edge of the platform. She screams as the chip continues to spark, and Adora makes another appeal to the Catra she knows is still present, still fighting.

"Come on, Catra! You've never listened to anyone in your life. Are you really going to start now?"

Catra turns, her eyes flashing back to their conventional colors.

"You are such an idiot," Catra says, affection written plainly on her face.

Adora chokes out in response, "Yeah, I know!"

Catra giggles at the exchange, and the sound is sweeter than any cake in Bright Moon's kitchens. The chip's influence overtakes Catra once more, and Adora pours out her heart.

"I'm going to take you home!"

Catra's cheeks are stained with tears. "Promise?"

Adora reaches out her hand. "I promise!"

"Adora…"

Catra reaches out to meet her. Their hands are nearly touching; Adora has never made it this far, gotten this close. She's *speaking with Catra,* she's going to save her and protect her and—

Before their hands can meet, Catra gasps and is forced into a stiff, upright pose. Prime's light has returned to her eyes, and their voice rings out, raspy and nightmarish.

"Disappointing. Some creatures are destined only for destruction."

There's a sickening glow as electricity arcs from the chip; Catra screams, a final, haunting sound that Adora knows better than she has any right to. Catra's rigid body suddenly goes limp—a yell rips from Adora's throat as she surges forward—Catra crumples, and—

She falls over the edge, a split second before Adora can catch her.

Adora stands in stunned silence.

This is the part where she drops to her knees and bursts into arcane flames. This is the part where it resets, all her unprecedented progress wiped clean and her memory slowly erased. This is the part where she knows in her heart that Catra is dead.

Except that Catra isn't dead. She was fighting, she was *there,* and Adora made her a promise.

She doesn't intend to break it.

She jumps.

***

Adora wakes from unconsciousness with a groan.

Light filters down from far, *far* above, and she scans her surroundings. It's darker down here, featureless save for—she gasps as she spots Catra's tiny, broken frame. Adora pushes herself to stand, but instantly falls back to the floor; her legs are shattered and useless, and it's only then that she notices the screaming, searing agony in every facet of her body.

But the pain is dull, quieted against the enormity of Catra laying mere feet away, Catra, who may yet be alive. Adora crawls.

"Catra… Catra?" She cradles what she hopes isn't Catra's corpse. "It's okay… I'm here." Catra is delicate, brittle, and—breathing!

It's the faintest, saddest sound, almost a sob, but it's enough for Adora. She buries her face into Catra's shoulder, enveloping the one she loves as she cries freely.

Multiple sets of footsteps echo around her, and she's callously ripped from her moment of joy by Prime's grating, gloating voice.

"I am sorry for the needless waste, Adora."

Adora tenses, but does not dignify him with a response. She sniffles.

"It did not have to be like this."

Adora stays where she is, listening to the rise and fall of Catra's chest, the scratch of her weak, tired lungs battling for every gasp. Catra is alive.

"Are you ready to cooperate?"

The words don't even make it to her head. She steadies her own breathing, running gentle fingers through Catra's newly-shorn hair. It's a small, tender gesture, and her last before she makes a critical decision. Adora lowers Catra and exposes herself, eyes still shut tight.

Catra is alive.

In response she feels a rush of power, originating in her gut and exploding outward into every cell of her body; it's magic unlike any she's ever felt. It's flame, like when she begins a new loop, but there is no affliction. It's healthy and warm, like the magic of the memories, but it builds rather than takes away. It's familiar, like the She-Ra of the sword, but this time there's nothing holding her back.

She opens her eyes, and they burn with magical fury.

A column of light forms around her and Catra, blue and lovely and perfect, and she stands. Her legs are working once again, healed in an instant by the unstoppable wave of magic. Completely on faith, Adora raises her right arm for a sword that isn't there, automatically procuring the words that she's missed so much.

"For the honor… of… Grayskull!!"

A sword takes shape in her outstretched hand. She is blinding, and in an incomprehensible flash, Adora stretches and grows to an imposing size.

She is She-Ra once more. Adora spares a glance at Catra, her reason for fighting, still breathing and still held safely.

She looks up and it's a stark contrast: before her is the one responsible for Catra's current state, for her countless deaths and for the suffering of her friends. Prime inhabits a clone, not even confident enough to be present himself. He and the clones that surround him squint against the radiance of Adora's new form.

As she looks at her tormentor, she allows herself to feel every emotion that she's suppressed, denied, or forgotten, and rage mingles with joy in a volatile concoction. With more power than she's ever possessed, Adora frowns, throws Catra over her shoulder, and utterly wastes the enemy before her.

A slash of her brand-new sword here, a bashing of the skull there, she ties it all together with an effortless backflip-kick that shatters more bones. Her sword channels an impossibly large blast of magic directly at Horde Prime's vessel, and she walks through the carnage toward his incapacitated body.

"You miscalculated," Adora says, spitting Prime's own words back at him. The spark of Prime's consciousness slips from the pair of green eyes, and the clone drops dead on the spot.

There's a beat of silence, but Adora knows she has no time to waste. Her job is far from finished. She surveys the aftermath of her victory, and, satisfied that every clone has been thoroughly disabled or destroyed, she allows her sword to vanish into the air. She hoists Catra into her arms, locates an elevator, and hurriedly attempts to operate it as Prime's ship continues shaking. When she reaches the top, she navigates the hallways with speed and confidence, laser-focused on Catra's safety.

I have to save her, I have to get her home. I have to save her, I have to get her home. I have to save her, I have to—

An enormous crash rocks the ship, snapping Adora from her thoughts and causing her to yelp. She has no idea what her friends have done with this new, experimental loop, but it seems to involve extensive damage to Prime's home. She runs toward the noise, wishing all the while for her long-since obliterated comm. Catra's weightless form is held bridal-style in her arms, bouncing with each footfall but still safe, still with her.

C'mon, c'mon…

She turns a corner, and her shining brilliance reveals a darkened, partially blocked hall. She moves toward the heap of rubble, cresting it to find Glimmer and Bow, whose mouths suddenly hang open in twin expressions of incredulity.

"She-Ra," Bow mutters after a moment.

"She's back!" Glimmer exclaims.

Adora reaches her friends and gives a small smile as she fondly gazes down at Catra. It's not an explanation, not even close, but she hopes it can convey the depth of her relief, the improbability of this outcome.

Before she can speak, several clones make themselves known among the debris. She quickly hands Catra to Bow—confident that he will keep her safe, he's always been the kindest soul—and draws her ethereal sword for a second time. She needs no words, only the knowledge that she's literal seconds away from her goal, that she's *so close to saving Catra.*

The clones advance while Adora traces a rainbow pattern in the sky with her blade. She doesn't know what it'll do, but she knows, somehow, that she must do it.

Her enemies are snarling as they close in, but she's quick on the draw; she flicks her sword and activates the dormant magic, yelling as she unleashes a blast that knocks every one of her opponents off their feet. None get back up. She surveys her work, and turns to make her way up Darla's ramp.

On board, hidden alarms splash a crimson illumination against the interior of Darla's cabin.

"Shields at thirty percent," Darla announces. "Hull compromised. Interspace travel not recommended."

Adora spots Bow and Glimmer laying Catra down to rest, but she strides past them and meets Entrapta at the console. She lays a powerful hand on the dashboard, imbuing it with a touch of magic and causing it to light up at her presence.

"Administrator detected. Hello, She-Ra."

"Hey, Darla. Get us out of here."

"Affirmative."

The ship begins to shake and scrape as it frees itself from the wreckage of Prime's ship. Adora narrows her eyes and adds, "And Darla? Make it quick."

Darla erupts from the Velvet Glove at incalculable speeds, hurtling toward home. With one obstacle out of the way, Adora moves on to the larger and more terrifying of the two: Catra, resting in Glimmer's lap, has stopped moving.

Adora joins Glimmer and Bow on the floor, taking Catra's head in her hands and immediately tearing up.

"C'mon, Catra," Adora breathes. "You're not done. Not yet." She holds Catra's limp form closer, cradling her in the hug she wishes she could have given her all these many loops and repetitions. She touches their foreheads together.

"We're going home," Adora barely manages to get out.

From deep within her, a vibrant, gentle fire glows. She wills it to spread through her body, to reach her skin and dance across it, down her arms, into her fingertips and finally into Catra. It's blue, it's gold, it's red, it's every color and every feeling and every time she almost said "I love you" but cut herself short, every time she wanted something and pushed it down because it was all too impossible or selfish.

She concentrates on knitting bones, restoring life to dead cells, mending bruises, nurturing the tiniest, most unlikely spark of life that still exists inside Catra. All of her magic goes into the task, and finally, even a part of herself. The light surrounding her grows in intensity, leaking in through her eyelids and enveloping her entire world.

When she's given everything she possibly can, Adora opens her eyes to discover that she's returned to her normal state, having even given up the temporary control of her newfound power.

Catra remains still. Adora takes short, irregular breaths as panic creeps back under her skin.

What if it wasn't enough?

Catra doesn't move.

What if it doesn't work, and she slips away again?

Catra still doesn't move.

What if… what if she—

Catra coughs and splutters, and Adora's heart soars.

Catra recovers patiently, slowly, looking up with tired but focused eyes. She whispers, "Hey, Adora."

All Adora can do is smile and hug Catra once more. Catra hugs right back, with all of her strength.

A purr emanates from Catra's core, gently rhythmic in the non-existent space between the two. Adora holds Catra, and Catra holds Adora. Years of war and resentment melt away in the face of their embrace, and, although Adora does not yet know it, so do her memories of the loops.

She-Ra's magic has done more than mend bone and bring Catra back from the edge; it's also soothed Adora's exhausted mind for the last time.

Catra and Adora have been holding one another for too long. Adora *knows* that it's been too long, she can feel Bow and Glimmer's questioning eyes boring into her skull, but she doesn't care.

"I've got you," she whispers, only for Catra's sensitive ears. Catra does not respond with words, and simply clings to Adora more fervently.

Glimmer and Bow each say a word of encouragement before getting up, granting the pair some space and all the time they need.

Only after an unknowable eternity do Catra and Adora begin to separate. It comes in waves, moving one inch at a time until eventually they are face-to-face again, foreheads touching as their eyes are closed.

“Thank you,” Catra mumbles. Adora smiles in response, truly happy for the first time she can remember.

She breathes deeply, freely.

Catra is alive.

Adora has won.

Chapter End Notes

Well, that's it. My second-ever completed fic, and it's been a blast! I hope you all enjoyed this rendition of canon events through a canon divergent perspective, and that you'll leave me a comment with your favorite loops or moments. I read every comment and (try to) respond to them all! I look forward to any feedback.

If you want more of my writing, check out Muscle Memory! Post-canon Catradora memory loss mystery abounds. It's my most experimental and ambitious fic yet, and I'm really proud of what I've got.

Thank you a million times over for reading, commenting, sharing, bookmarking, and for being the reason I wrote this fic. Thank you!! Until next time <3

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!